

# Leader Marches as an Opposition Electoral Strategy

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## Abstract

Opposition parties often struggle in elections against populist incumbents. One extraordinary campaign tactic adopted across contexts by opposition parties facing populists is leader marches, where a party head treks across the country, engaging voters directly. This tactic addresses the image, reach, and electability challenges that populists impose. We study its consequences through the Indian National Congress leader's 150-day Bharat Jodo Yatra. A difference-in-differences design with newly collected election data shows that geographic exposure to the march helped Congress, but only near the route, in proximate elections, and where it was the principal opposition. Interviews and descriptive evidence show the march countered the party's elite image, overcame a pro-incumbent media environment, and signaled viability. An original survey a year later shows that reported participation correlates with favorable views of Congress. The article reveals that opposition extraordinary campaigning can make electoral inroads against entrenched populists, even if it fails to unseat them.

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Electoral campaigns regularly involve door-to-door canvassing (Auerbach et al. 2022; Gulzar et al. 2024; Goyal 2024; Pons 2018; Enos and Hersh 2015), rallies (Horowitz 2016; Paget 2019; Arriola et al. 2024; Brierley and Kramon 2020; Szwarcberg 2012; Sheikh 2024; Snyder and Yousaf 2020), and town halls (Wantchekon and Guardado 2024; Fujiwara and Wantchekon 2013). Sometimes party leaders move beyond these typical tactics and take up more extraordinary forms of campaigning. One such type of campaigning is leader marches, where a politician will travel on foot, often for weeks or months, to directly meet and engage with voters. Examples include Connecticut Senator Chris Murphy’s annual multi-week walk across the state to meet voters, South Indian politician Chandrababu Naidu’s *Vastunna Mee Kosam* (“I am coming for you”) 208-day march across the state of Andhra Pradesh starting in 2012, and Brazil Workers’ Party leader Lula da Silva’s Caravan of Hope trek ahead of his planned run in the 2018 presidential elections.<sup>1</sup> These campaigns are costly and considered inefficient under logics of vote-buying and clientelism in developing democracies (Mares and Young 2016; Kramon 2017; Hicken and Nathan 2020) and findings on the limited persuasive effects of campaign contact in Western contexts (Kalla and Broockman 2018). Yet, these leader marches continue as a campaign tactic worldwide. And, in recent years, a distinctive actor has adopted them at the national level: opposition leaders confronting entrenched populist incumbents. From the Republican People’s Party’s Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu in Turkey and the Tisza Party’s Peter Magyar in Hungary to Chadema’s Freeman Mbowe in Tanzania and the Indian National Congress’s Rahul Gandhi in India, opposition leaders who differ in prominence, ideology, and setting have converged on the same tactic. This article theorizes why leader marches may specifically help opposition parties facing populist incumbents at the ballot box and provides quantitative and qualitative evidence on the electoral consequences of this strategy.

Understanding how opposition parties use this electoral tactic against populist, often democratic-eroding incumbents is important because, while elections are a decisive way to end a populist’s reign and restore liberal pluralism, an electoral victory is also very difficult to achieve (Weyland 2025; Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018). While in power, populists often reshape the terrain on which

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<sup>1</sup>News reports covered Murphy’s march in the US, Naidu’s march in India, and da Silva’s march in Brazil.

the subsequent election is fought. They can brand the opposition as corrupt, out-of-touch elites (Mudde 2004; Bonikowski 2019), tilt the information environment toward themselves while starving challengers of coverage (Grzymala-Busse 2019), and cultivate a sense of inevitability that makes opposition victory seem unlikely (Bermeo 2016). This harms the opposition's image, reach, and perceived viability, which ordinary campaign tactics may struggle to offset. We argue that while leader marches may work generally for parties for a range of reasons, they are uniquely capable of helping the opposition overcome these disadvantages because they are unusually costly and visible forms of campaigning. Walking across the country signals commitment to ordinary voters, generates attention even in restrictive media environments, and displays a party's organizational capacity. Leader marches therefore help opposition parties counter accusations of elitism, expand their public reach, and strengthen perceptions of electoral viability.

We study the consequences of this tactic in the context of India, where the opposition Indian National Congress (INC) sought to counter its entrenched out-of-touch reputation and mobilize support following two consecutive national losses to the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and electoral setbacks across several Indian states (Ziegfeld 2020; Vaishnav and Hinton 2019). The BJP used a populist strategy that effectively branded the Congress as inept, corrupt, and elitist, exacerbating the continued decline of the party (Varshney, Ayyangar and Swaminathan 2021; Naseemullah and Chhibber 2024). While not at the same level as some populists in Europe and Latin America, the party has nonetheless engaged in tactics, including media suppression, exploiting electoral finance regulations, and mobilizing anti-minority sentiment (Vaishnav 2025; Varshney 2022; Tudor 2023; Allie 2025). In response, Congress Party leader Rahul Gandhi undertook a 150-day-long march, the Bharat Jodo Yatra ("Unite India March", hereafter referred to as BJY or the yatra), across India with the stated goal of uniting the country, listening to citizen concerns, and pitching an alternative vision for the idea of India. The yatra was a leader march from the opposition, like the Justice March in Turkey and the March of One Million Steps in Hungary.

We analyze how voter exposure to and participation in the yatra impacted their political behavior

and ultimately the electoral prospects of the Congress Party.<sup>2</sup> Using the party's social media and official daily reports, we reconstruct the BJY's route across India and validate it with party officials. We merge these data with state and national election data. Our main specification uses a difference-in-differences design to examine the impact of the yatra. The design relies on the idea that, while constituencies where the yatra did and did not pass through are certainly different from one another, absent the yatra, both types of constituencies would have followed parallel electoral trajectories. As a robustness exercise, we also estimate this design on a matched sample of treated and control constituencies based on pre-treatment electoral and political characteristics.

We find that constituencies exposed to the BJY experienced an average increase of approximately 4.49 percentage points in Congress vote share in proximate state elections. While the national elections held eighteen months later show no overall effect, the march increased INC's vote share by 4.69 percentage points in states where Congress was the principal opposition to the BJP. These estimates are comparable when using the matched sample, underscoring that the results are not driven by pre-existing differences between yatra and non-yatra constituencies. To further understand the impact of voter exposure to the yatra, we use geo-located polling station-level election results across two election cycles in the first state to hold an election after the yatra concluded (where we found overall effects in our first analysis). Across several empirical approaches, we find that the electoral impact of the yatra was concentrated in polling stations located very close to the route. Together, the observational analyses reveal that the yatra improved Congress's vote share but only under specific conditions: when elections were temporally proximate, when constituencies were spatially near the yatra route, and when Congress was the central opposition party.

Through interviews with Congress officials and voters, Google Search trends, and descriptive data on follow-up rallies, we find evidence that the leader marches like the yatra can be particularly effective when used by opposition parties against populist incumbents because they address three

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<sup>2</sup>News articles have pointed to the impact of the yatra (See [Hindustan Times](#)). [Verma and Pratikshit \(2024\)](#) discusses the role of the yatra as part of Congress's broader 2024 election strategy and [Choudhary and Mishra \(2024\)](#) begin to examine the impact of the yatra by comparing the 2019 and 2024 national elections. This paper moves beyond this existing work by theorizing the broader category of campaigns that the yatra is an example of, estimating the impact of the yatra in state and national elections, and investigating the mechanisms by which the yatra influenced political behavior through interviews and an original survey.

key problems that the opposition faces in these contexts: an elite narrative, a pro-incumbent political environment, and perceptions of poor viability. This helps explain why opposition actors facing populist incumbents may adopt the tactic and why it can produce electoral benefits for them.

We then investigate the individual-level impact of the yatra by studying participation in the yatra through an original telephone survey of 3,510 voters. We find that voters across the political spectrum participated in the yatra and that self-reported participation in the yatra is associated with improved perceptions of the opposition, increased discourse about the INC, and higher engagement with the INC in the year after the yatra. Despite the challenges with self-reported participation, the association holds across several subsets of the sample, including voters who supported the BJP in 2019. The results underscore that leader marches can reach voters who previously supported the ruling party and can generate durable improvements, a year after the campaign, with voters who were directly engaged with the march, even if the broader electoral impact may decay.

This article makes several contributions. First, it identifies and evaluates the effectiveness of an electoral strategy through which opposition parties respond to populist incumbents. A growing body of literature examines how opposition parties can respond to populism and its associated democratic backsliding (Gamboa 2023; Cleary and Öztürk 2022; McCoy and Somer 2021; Riedl et al. 2024). While much of this work centers on aggressive or extra-institutional actions (Bourne 2023; Gamboa 2023) such as protests or coups and institutional responses, including coalition-building (Ziegfeld and Tudor 2017; Samet 2024; Ong 2022) and judicial intervention (Cleary and Öztürk 2022; Gamboa, García-Holgado and González-Ocantos 2024), elections remain the most decisive way to remove populist incumbents (Weyland 2025). Existing work notes that opposition campaigns can use civil society and grassroots efforts to take on populist incumbents (Folsz 2026; Bill and Stanley 2025). We contribute to this work on electoral strategies that can help the opposition by pointing to the value of extraordinary campaigning, like leader marches.

Second, we extend research on campaigning by examining an unusually intensive form of voter contact and by focusing on a Global South democracy. While the effectiveness of campaigning strategies is extensively studied in Western contexts (Snyder and Yousaf 2020; Enos and Hersh

2015; Pons 2018), research on low and middle-income democracies often studies campaigns as a way to understand ethnic politics and clientelism (Ferree 2010; Horowitz 2016; Arriola et al. 2024; Szwarberg 2012). This article joins recent work that studies party campaigning in its own right in the Global South (Paget 2019; Brierley and Kramon 2020; Sheikh 2024). In doing so, it underscores that costly and extraordinary campaign tactics can reach voters beyond standard electioneering strategies; however, their electoral impact has limits.

Third, the article advances work on Indian politics by exploring one pathway through which the once-dominant Congress Party is attempting organizational renewal. With the resurgence of populism worldwide, scholars have focused largely on Latin America and Europe. This paper joins recent research on populism in South Asia (Vaishnav 2019; Varshney, Ayyangar and Swaminathan 2021; Naseemullah and Chhibber 2024) but goes beyond the rise of populism to focus on opposition responses. In the context of India, while extensive research considers the decline of the Congress Party (Chhibber 2001; Tudor and Ziegfeld 2019; Jaffrelot and Kumar 2012), their attempts to rebuild are understudied. Moreover, prior work highlights the long history of walking-based voter mobilization in India, including Gandhi's Salt march, the Ram Rath Yatra, and religious and funeral processions (Bhavnani and Jha 2014; Blakeslee 2018; Hinton and Vaishnav 2023; Daxecker, Prasad and Batra 2025). This paper examines the most recent high-profile attempt by the Congress leadership to mobilize mass support through the walking-based mobilization of a leader march, offering insights into how parties might rebuild.

## **Leader Marches as an Opposition Electoral Strategy**

Leader marches are campaigns in which political leaders spend weeks or months walking across a country or region while engaging citizens directly. Unlike rallies or canvassing, these campaigns combine sustained face-to-face interaction with highly visible symbolic action. They are costly in terms of time, organization, and political commitment, making them an unusual electoral strategy. Precisely because they are unusually costly, leader marches may influence voters in a way that conventional campaign activities cannot.

Any party—incumbent or opposition; right or left; elite, ethnic, or movement—can use leader marches for party-building and voter engagement. Yet many prominent examples over the past decade, such as those in Turkey, Hungary, India, and Tanzania, involve opposition parties deploying them against democracy-eroding populists. By nature of not being in government, these opposition parties lack access to executive resources, patronage, and institutional levers that could be used to influence voters, making these leader marches attractive. We argue that leader marches are particularly valuable for opposition parties competing against populist incumbents because they generate credible public signals. By investing resources into prolonged, visible engagement with citizens, opposition leaders can demonstrate commitment, organizational capacity, and electoral seriousness. These signals help counter three disadvantages that populist incumbents frequently impose on their challengers: an elite reputation, restricted public visibility, and doubts about electoral viability. We do not argue that other parties are unable to use this tactic, but rather that it can address the particular vulnerabilities that the opposition faces under populist incumbents.

## **An Elite Image**

Central to populist ideology is a binary moral division between “the pure people” and “the corrupt elite” (Mudde 2004). Populists argue that their opposition represents elite interests and is disconnected from the mass public. In Brazil, Jair Bolsonaro branded the Workers’ Party as corrupt elites on his path to victory (Hunter and Power 2019). In the United States, Trump positioned establishment Democratic elites as having betrayed “true members of the nation in favor of minorities, immigrants, and other putative outsiders” (Bonikowski 2019, 11). In power, populists often deploy this elite-versus-people rhetoric to delegitimize opposition forces. The persistence of this framing constrains the opposition’s ability to reclaim credibility and rebuild support.

In response to this elite framing, opposition leaders must actively reconnect with voters and demonstrate responsiveness to the concerns of the general public in a costly and meaningful way. Leader marches offer this because they involve the leader traveling extensively across the country, meeting voters in their communities, and listening to their concerns and grievances. In the 2020 election in Tanzania, Freeman Mbowe, the chairman of the opposition party Chadema, engaged in

this type of campaign. The ruling CCM under John Magufuli in Tanzania employed populist “elite versus the masses” rhetoric along with engaging in democratic backsliding tactics (Paget 2019). Mbowe’s “walking rallies,” in which he connected directly with citizens on the ground, sought to counter the opposition’s elite image. When he was stopped by police forces, he said “how can I not speak to the people while they stop me and want to speak with me” highlighting his effort to connect with citizens while security forces wanted to stop him (Kwayu 2023, 266).

## **Pro-Incumbent Political Environment**

The opposition faces challenges in voter outreach due to attempts by populists, particularly those with undemocratic tendencies, to control the political ecosystem. When in power, populist parties often concentrate control over the media and undermine independent outlets. For example, Fidesz in Hungary used laws to marginalize or eliminate critical media outlets and the PiS in Poland attacked public media, ultimately placing it under partisan control to use for propaganda (Grzymala-Busse 2019). In India, under Modi, major news networks frequently avoid criticizing the ruling party, constrained by threats of state harassment and financial retaliation (Tudor and Ziegfeld 2019). At the same time, allied business elites also acquired previously independent television channels, tightening the ruling party’s grip over the media landscape. This weakened the opposition’s ability to communicate with the public and articulate a compelling alternative.

Leader marches can generate critical visibility and public attention for opposition parties in environments where populist incumbents have monopolized or suppressed independent media. When opposition leaders march across the country, it is often a spectacle that generates coverage both within and outside the country, even if the populist-controlled media ignore it. During the Justice March in Turkey, while the state-run media highlighted the march as a threat to public order, independent and international media provided favorable coverage and segments of the march were live-streamed across social media platforms. In May 2025, Peter Magyar from the Tisza Party, the key opposition to Orban’s Fidesz in Hungary, walked 300 kilometers from Budapest to Oradea, Romania as part of the One Million Steps March. The effort drew widespread media attention in a constrained pro-Fidesz environment, engaged Hungarians in Romania who often vote in Hungarian

elections, and led to reports that Tisza would have enough support to defeat Fidesz today. This coverage allowed the opposition to break through restrictive media and reach a wider audience.

## **Perceptions of Poor Viability**

When populist incumbents undertake democracy-eroding actions, voters may come to see their victory as inevitable, further dampening the opposition's prospects of winning back voters. Populists are often known to systematically manipulate elections by tilting the electoral playing field in their favor in a way that is not obviously fraudulent (Bermeo 2016). This involves actions such as unequal access to campaign finance, administrative interference in voter registration, and the intimidation or legal persecution of opposition candidates. When populist incumbents pursue these strategies, they can foster a sense of futility among opposition supporters, signaling that electoral competition is meaningless or unwinnable. For example, in the lead-up to Turkey's 2023 elections, Erdoğan used legal charges to ban the prominent Istanbul mayor from contesting for national office. While the mayor appealed the decision, the opposition ultimately refrained from nominating him as their presidential candidate, signaling opposition weakness (Esen and Gumuscu 2023).

Leader marches can suggest to voters that the opposition is indeed viable even in a tilted electoral playing field. An opposition leader traveling across broad geographic regions can communicate the presence of party infrastructure and organizational strength. For example, Chadema's walking rallies in Tanzania were perceived as only possible due to the party's deep grassroots-level efforts (Kwayu 2023). Similarly, when Lula's Caravan of Hope effort was seen as returning to the grassroots mobilization that originally forged the Workers' Party from a mass movement (Keck 1986). By engaging in a leader march, opposition parties can demonstrate the party's organizational capacity and present themselves as credible alternatives to populist incumbents.

## **The Electoral Consequences of Leader Marches**

While opposition parties across contexts engage in leader marches, their electoral consequences are underexplored. Because these campaigns address several key challenges that the opposition faces, they may help produce electoral gains. Still, several factors could limit this potential impact.

First, the populist incumbent's grip on their voter base may be too entrenched for such campaigns to significantly sway public opinion. Furthermore, swing voters may not actively engage with these marches, which instead might primarily engage opposition supporters. Finally, realizing substantive gains from a leader march likely requires sustained engagement rather than a large-scale but one-time effort. These countervailing dynamics create ambiguous expectations regarding the effectiveness of these campaigns in shifting voter perceptions and altering electoral outcomes, and the conditions under which their impact might be limited.

## **Context: The Bharat Jodo Yatra in India**

We examine how the opposition Congress Party sought to make electoral inroads against the BJP through Rahul Gandhi's leader march, the Bharat Jodo Yatra. The BJP under Prime Minister Narendra Modi exhibited common elements of populism. In the 2014 election, Modi framed the Congress Party as corrupt and elite and himself as the authentic voice of the masses (Jaffrelot 2021). By 2019, when the BJP won its second victory, Modi continued to pitch himself as representing the masses, which was increasingly pitched as the Hindu majority, further highlighting the party's Hindu nationalist ideology (Varshney, Ayyangar and Swaminathan 2021; Leidig and Mudde 2023). Alongside anti-minority rhetoric, the BJP curtailed space for dissent by tightening control over civil society and the press and enacting changes to campaign finance regulations that disproportionately advantaged the ruling party (Tudor 2023; Varshney 2022). In this context, opposition parties, especially the Congress, entered the 2024 national elections and several key state contests facing formidable constraints.<sup>3</sup>

Under these circumstances, Rahul Gandhi traveled over 4,000 kilometers (approximately 2,500 miles) on foot for over 150 days, starting in September 2022 in Tamil Nadu and ending in January 2023 in Jammu and Kashmir as part of the BJY. During the yatra, Gandhi would walk about 25 kilometers per day with party leaders, party workers, and voters, stopping for events, speeches, public meetings, and corner meetings (small targeted meetings with local influentials and civil society organizations). Citizens could join the march for a few minutes, several kilometers, or

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<sup>3</sup>In Appendix A we provide additional context on Congress' decline and the rise of the BJP.

multiple days, and many local residents lined up along the roadside to greet participants, raise local grievances, or participate in public meetings. The extended walking format created repeated opportunities for engagement with Rahul Gandhi and other Congress officials through informal conversations, small group discussions, and symbolic actions that would have been difficult to replicate through conventional rallies. Rahul Gandhi stated “we interact with people in between the Yatra. We hear people’s ‘mann ki baat’ (speaking from the heart) for about eight hours and speak for about 15 minutes.”<sup>4</sup> The INC research team provided Gandhi with a memo about “key issues in the region” to help direct the topics he covered<sup>5</sup>. Topics included state and local issues in the area, such as land distribution, health facilities, and national highways. Gandhi described the march as an effort to listen to citizens’ concerns and present an “alternate vision for the idea of India” rather than an electoral campaign.<sup>6</sup> In Appendix A we provide details on a sample day during the yatra from interviews with participants.

While (pada)yatras, or marches on foot, hold historical importance in India, the yatra remained extraordinary. Perhaps the most famous yatra remains Mahatma Gandhi’s Dandi March in 1930, a non-violent protest against the British salt tax that galvanized mass participation and drew international attention to India’s independence movement (Bhavnani and Jha 2014). In the case of the BJY, the event was especially seen as extraordinary because Rahul Gandhi had never engaged in this form of mobilization before and was, in fact, often criticized by his political opponents for being frequently outside the country.

## Data and Empirical Approach

Our main analysis estimates the causal impact of the yatra on electoral support for the Congress. Given our interest in both the promise and limits of this strategy, we also examine the extent to which its impact is temporally and geographically bounded.

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<sup>4</sup>NDTV Interview with Rahul Gandhi

<sup>5</sup>Author interview with Congress team member. January 7, 2024. Bangalore Urban District

<sup>6</sup>BBC - Bharat Jodo Yatra: Rahul Gandhi’s unity march ends in Kashmir

## Bharat Jodo Yatra Route

Using official online sources from the Congress Party and triangulating with social media coverage and official daily party accounts, we construct a continuous route of over 4,000 kilometers traveled by the yatra from September 7, 2022, to January 30, 2023. We then validated our route with INC officials. In Appendix B we provide more details on the data collection and construction of the yatra route. We use this route (shown in Figure 1) to identify “treated” electoral constituencies or places where the yatra crossed.

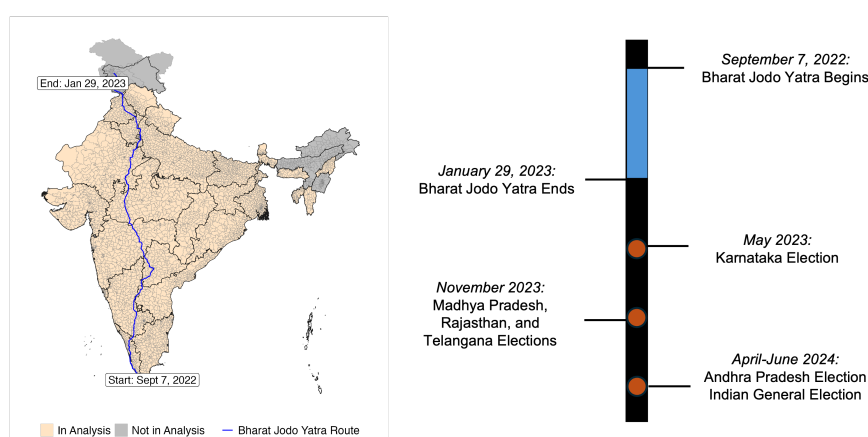


Figure 1: BJI Route and Timeline

The process of selecting the yatra route was not random, but rather involved input from Rahul Gandhi, Congress leaders, and members of the party organization. In Appendix C, Tables C.1 and C.2, we show how yatra and non-yatra constituencies differ based on variables from the election before the yatra for both state and national elections. In both state and national elections, yatra constituencies had significantly higher Congress vote share. In national elections, yatra constituencies were also more likely to experience a Congress win. Interviews with Congress party functionaries corroborate this, emphasizing that the yatra focused on places where voters “could be receptive to the party.”<sup>7</sup> Local party leaders in places with a strong party organization lobbied for the yatra in their area and state leaders lobbied for the yatra to spend longer in their state. At the same time, because the march was along a major highway where a large group of people could

<sup>7</sup>Author interview with Congress leader. January 7, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

join, some locations were also selected for convenience. Due to the inherent differences in where the yatra did and did not travel, our empirical approach does not rely on the claim that the yatra route was random.

## Congress Electoral Performance

We examine the impact of the yatra on Congress’s electoral performance in state and national elections. We focus on state elections in five states with elections after the yatra and on the 2024 national elections. Figure 1 presents a timeline of the yatra and the relevant elections.

We restrict our analysis to elections held after 2008 to ensure comparable constituencies within an electoral delimitation. For state elections, we scrape the most recent assembly constituency-level (AC) results from the Election Commission of India and obtain the previous electoral data from the Trivedi Centre for Political Data (TCPD) (Agarwal et al. 2022). For the main national-level analysis, we use data at the AC level as well, allowing more fine-grained data than results at the parliamentary constituency level.<sup>8</sup> We manually collect the vote share for the Congress candidate for each assembly constituency from each state-level Election Commission website for the most recent national elections and obtain the prior AC-level results from TCPD. In Appendix B we provide additional details on the election data.

## Research Design

We estimate the average effect of direct geographic exposure to the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress vote share in subsequent elections, relative to the counterfactual change that would have occurred in the same constituencies had the yatra not passed through them, under the assumption of parallel trends. Our analysis relies on a standard difference-in-differences framework:

$$Y_{it} = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{BJY}_i \times \text{Post}_t) + \gamma_i + \theta_t + \delta_s \times t + \epsilon_{it}$$

In the equation,  $Y_{it}$  denotes vote share for Congress in constituency  $i$  during election year  $t$ .  $\text{BJY}_i$  dummy takes the value 1 if the yatra passes through constituency  $i$ .  $\text{Post}_t$  equals 1 if the election was held after the yatra.  $\gamma_i$  and  $\theta_t$  are constituency and election year fixed effects, respectively. In

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<sup>8</sup>There are 543 parliamentary constituencies (PC) in India with 5-9 ACs per PC.

analyses that pool multiple states (notably the national election analysis), we additionally include state-specific linear time trends,  $\delta_s \times t$ , to account for state-level factors that may evolve differently over time. Standard errors are clustered at the AC level, which is the level at which treatment is defined. The coefficient of interest,  $\beta_1$ , captures the average effect of direct yatra exposure on Congress vote share. In additional analyses reported in the Appendix, we also operationalize treatment using distance to the yatra route and demonstrate robustness to Conley standard errors that account for spatial correlation.

Our identification strategy does not assume that the yatra route was randomly selected. Instead, it assumes that, conditional on constituency fixed effects, election-year fixed effects, and state-specific trends, treated and untreated constituencies would have experienced similar changes in Congress vote share absent the march. We strengthen this design by matching treated constituencies to observationally similar controls before estimating the difference-in-differences model. Importantly, the matching procedure does not alter the identifying assumption of parallel trends, but instead reduces reliance on extrapolation by limiting comparisons to more similar units.

## **The Electoral Impact of the Bharat Jodo Yatra**

We test how exposure to the yatra impacted the electoral outcomes for the Congress party in state and national elections. We focus on Congress vote share as our primary outcome; however, we report results related to the likelihood of a Congress win in Appendix D.2, Table D.3 and Appendix D.1, Table D.2. We further collect polling station-level data from the first election after the yatra to examine the spatial limits of leader marches.

### **State Elections**

We estimate the effect of the yatra on state legislative assembly elections, concentrating on five states (Karnataka, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Telangana, and Andhra Pradesh) where the yatra traversed and elections were held. We report the effect of the yatra on Congress vote share in Table 1. In Model 1, which focuses on all five states, the yatra increased the INC's vote share by 3.39 percentage points, equivalent to an increase of approximately one-fifth of a standard

deviation. When disaggregating the analysis by the timing of elections, we find that the effect is concentrated in races held approximately seven months after the yatra passed through the state, namely, the Karnataka elections. By the time of the electoral races, 11 months or more after the yatra (Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Telangana, and Andhra Pradesh elections), the estimated effects on Congress's vote share are small and statistically insignificant. In Karnataka, constituencies traversed by the yatra experienced a 4.49 percentage point increase in INC vote share—representing a 12% gain relative to the state's average Congress vote share. The event study in Figure 2 confirms the parallel trends assumption for the positive and statistically significant effects observed in elections held seven months after the yatra.

Table 1: Effect Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in State Elections

|                         | DV: Congress Vote Share |                                |                                    |                                 |
|-------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
|                         | all state elections     | elections 7 months since yatra | elections 11-13 months since yatra | elections 19 months since yatra |
|                         | (1)                     | (2)                            | (3)                                | (4)                             |
| $BJY_i \times Post_t$   | 3.39***<br>(1.26)       | 4.49**<br>(2.05)               | -0.11<br>(1.44)                    | 0.20<br>(0.89)                  |
| Observations            | 3747                    | 891                            | 2160                               | 696                             |
| Year FEs                | ✓                       | ✓                              | ✓                                  | ✓                               |
| AC FEs                  | ✓                       | ✓                              | ✓                                  | ✓                               |
| Number of Clusters (AC) | 948                     | 224                            | 549                                | 175                             |
| Mean of DV              | 32.29                   | 38.38                          | 36.57                              | 11.24                           |

Notes: \* $p < 0.1$ ; \*\* $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*\* $p < 0.01$ . Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level.

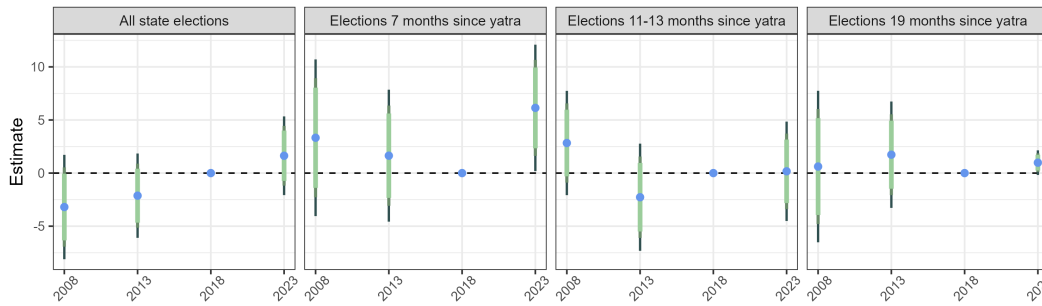


Figure 2: Effect on INC Vote Share in State Elections: Event Study

Notes: Election years are standardized to 2008, 2013, 2018, and 2024 (actual AP elections were in 2009, 2013, 2019, and 2024). Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level. We show 90%, 95%, and 99% CIs.

In Table D.1 in Appendix D.1, we examine how the distance to the yatra (measured from the distance of the route to the centroid of a constituency) affects Congress's vote in state elections. The approach is preferable to comparing yatra constituencies to nearby constituencies since constituency

sizes vary so some nearby constituencies would be more likely to have exposure than others. Similar to the results in Table 1, we observe an aggregate effect for all state elections, primarily driven by Karnataka. In Karnataka, the result suggests that a greater distance from the yatra route is associated with a lower Congress vote share. It is worth noting that in the 2023 Karnataka elections, the incumbent was viewed as corrupt and ineffective, facing an uphill battle, which may have set the context for Congress to see vote share improvements. However, in the Telangana state elections, which occurred 13 months after the yatra, there was also anti-incumbency against the ruling party of the state (the Bharat Rashtra Samithi) and we do not find an effect of the yatra. Moreover, in Karnataka, where the incumbent BJP faced statewide anti-incumbency, Congress's vote share increased *more* in constituencies directly exposed to the yatra than in comparable constituencies that were not exposed.

## National Elections

Next, we examine the effect of the yatra on Congress's vote share in national elections, focusing on different subsets of constituencies. Our results from the state elections reveal that as time passes, there may be no positive effect. The national elections were held 15 to 19 months after the yatra crossed a state, suggesting that it is unlikely that we will observe significant positive impacts of the yatra on Congress's vote share. However, some constituencies may exhibit lingering effects more than a year after the yatra.

Table 2: Effect of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in National Elections

|                         | DV: Congress Vote Share |                                  |                   |                                  |
|-------------------------|-------------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------|
|                         | Full Sample             |                                  | Matched Sample    |                                  |
|                         | All States              | Congress Strongholds (2009-2019) | All States        | Congress Strongholds (2009-2019) |
|                         | (1)                     | (2)                              | (3)               | (4)                              |
| $BJY_i \times Post_t$   | 0.29<br>(0.83)          | 2.13**<br>(0.97)                 | 3.01***<br>(1.06) | 4.69***<br>(1.26)                |
| Observations            | 12328                   | 9421                             | 1468              | 1129                             |
| Year FEs                | Yes                     | Yes                              | Yes               | Yes                              |
| AC FEs                  | Yes                     | Yes                              | Yes               | Yes                              |
| Number of Clusters (AC) | 3743                    | 2576                             | 384               | 289                              |
| Mean of DV              | 30.66                   | 31.61                            | 36.80             | 35.90                            |

Notes: \*p<0.1; \*\*p<0.05; \*\*\*p<0.01. Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level.

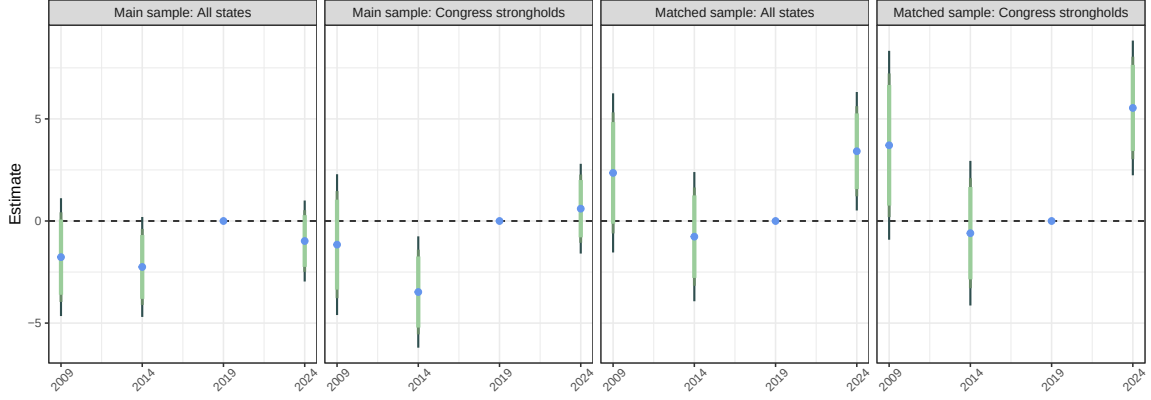


Figure 3: Event Study for 2024 National Election

*Notes:* Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level. We show 90%, 95%, and 99% CIs.

In Table 2, we show the effect of the yatra on Congress's vote share in national elections. In Model 1, focusing on all assembly constituencies, we find a small and statistically insignificant effect of the yatra on Congress vote share. One challenge with this all-India analysis is the role of alliances. In 2024, the INDIA alliance between Congress and other prominent regional parties led to various seat-sharing agreements across states. In some states, Congress was the leading alliance party, contesting the majority of the seats against the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance. These states would be more likely to have a longer-term effect of the yatra, given Congress's central role in national politics there. In Model 2, we focus on states where Congress was the main alliance party against the BJP. We measure this by identifying states where the INC contested in more than 80% of the constituencies in a state for the 2009-2019 elections.<sup>9</sup> In these states, we find that the yatra increased Congress's vote share by 2.13 percentage points. The event study in Figure 3, however, raises some concerns about the parallel trends assumption, which we seek to address through additional analysis using the difference-in-differences on a matched sample.

We then re-estimate the difference-in-differences specification for our national-level results using a matched sample. While our difference-in-differences empirical strategy accounts for time-invariant differences in covariates between treated and control units, performing a 1:1 nearest-

<sup>9</sup>We do not include the contesting details for 2024 to not incorporate a post-treatment outcome into the sample selection criteria.

neighbor Mahalanobis matching (one matched control unit for each treated unit) helps strengthen our identification by restricting our focus to more comparable units. This further helps address concerns with the parallel trends assumption in our national-level results. Table 3 reports covariate balance before and after matching. The standardized mean differences across all covariates decline substantially after matching, with nearly all values falling well below the conventional threshold of 0.1, indicating that the treated and control groups are now very comparable. We provide further diagnostics in the Appendix G.

Table 3: Covariate Balance Before and After Matching

| Variable                    | Before Matching |            |            | After Matching |            |            |
|-----------------------------|-----------------|------------|------------|----------------|------------|------------|
|                             | Treated         | Control    | Std. Diff. | Treated        | Control    | Std. Diff. |
| Effective Number of Parties | 2.458           | 2.357      | 0.210      | 2.458          | 2.455      | 0.007      |
| Share of GEN Constituency   | 0.781           | 0.685      | 0.232      | 0.781          | 0.781      | 0.000      |
| Share of SC Constituency    | 0.167           | 0.158      | 0.024      | 0.167          | 0.167      | 0.000      |
| Share of ST Constituency    | 0.052           | 0.157      | -0.473     | 0.052          | 0.052      | 0.000      |
| INC Vote Share              | 35.315          | 26.328     | 0.658      | 35.315         | 35.210     | 0.008      |
| INC Deposit Lost            | 0.089           | 0.324      | -0.829     | 0.089          | 0.089      | 0.000      |
| Total Electors in AC        | 228948.406      | 214592.766 | 0.222      | 228948.406     | 226239.865 | 0.042      |
| Voter Turnout               | 67.786          | 70.273     | -0.294     | 67.786         | 68.055     | -0.032     |

*Note:* Standardized mean differences are shown for each covariate in the sample before and after matching. Matched sample is from Mahalanobis-distance matching

Model 3 in Table 2 using the full matched sample shows that yatra constituencies experienced a 3.01 percentage point higher Congress vote share relative to matched comparable non-yatra constituencies. The magnitude of the estimated effect increases in states where Congress has historically been the principal opposition to the BJP. Specifically, in states where the INC contested more than 80% of the constituencies across the three pre-2024 elections (Model 4), the yatra increased Congress's vote share by 4.69 percentage points. The event study in Figure 3 provides evidence of parallel trends when using the matched sample. In Appendix D.2, we report several robustness checks. We present results at the parliamentary constituency level, which are in the same direction but are statistically insignificant, likely due to the broader treatment definition. We estimate the same model using distance to the yatra as the treatment, which shows the same substantive patterns. We demonstrate robustness to other matching procedures like propensity score matching and matching within states.

Overall, the effect of the yatra dissipated by the time of the national elections. However, across our analysis and robustness exercises there is still an observable positive effect in places where Congress was the key opposition party against the BJP. The yatra platformed Congress leaders and the Congress party, making its impact most likely in places where the Congress party, not other opposition parties, matters. The impact of the leader marches is therefore limited to the party that mobilized voters, with little spillover to allied parties.

## Detailed Study of the Karnataka State Elections

The analysis so far treats an assembly constituency as treated if the yatra crossed it and the supplementary analysis examines the distance from the yatra to the constituency centroid. However, with a constituency average size of 900 sq km and 200,000 voters, this broad definition of treatment may underestimate the yatra's effect. To generate a precise estimate of the yatra's effect, we move to the micro-level and focus on Karnataka, the first state to hold an election after the yatra.

We scrape and geo-locate polling-station-level election results for Karnataka in 2018 and 2023. At this level, treatment is defined as spatial proximity to the yatra route, which serves as a proxy for direct exposure to the march rather than indirect awareness through media or party messaging. Because polling station boundaries and identifiers change across elections, we are unable to construct a multi-period pre-treatment event study at the polling station level. The analysis, therefore, compares two elections and should be interpreted as difference-in-differences with limited pre-trend diagnostics. To match polling station overtime, we match them in two ways: first, by exact number match, which is less conservative and may include renumbered stations ("Number-Matched Sample"), and second, by exact station name match, which is more conservative ("Exact Name-Matched Sample"). Details are in Appendix E.

With these two samples, we estimate several two-period difference-in-differences models to examine how being proximate to the yatra route impacted Congress's vote share. The results are shown in Table 4. In Models 1 and 4, we define a polling station as treated if the yatra crossed through an assembly constituency in which the station is located.<sup>10</sup> We find that there is an 8.76-9.20

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<sup>10</sup>The percent of treated polling stations is 8.5% in the Number-Matched Sample and 7.7% in the Exact Name-

percentage point increase in Congress vote share in polling stations in assembly constituencies that the yatra crossed, reflecting about a 20% increase from the mean Congress vote share across both elections in Karnataka. These results are similar but slightly larger in magnitude when we define treatment based on whether the route crossed the area covered by the polling station (Models 2 and 5).<sup>11</sup> Finally, in Models 3 and 6, we use a continuous treatment of the log distance to the yatra route to examine how moving away from the yatra route impacted Congress's vote share. To understand this effect, consider two polling stations: one 10 km from the yatra route and another 100 km away. The station farther away would likely have a Congress vote share about 6.22 percentage points lower than the closer one. These results show larger effects than previous aggregate results, likely due to a more precise measure of yatra exposure and the focus on the first state that held elections after the yatra.

Table 4: Effect of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in National Elections

|                                                   | DV: Congress Vote Share |                    |                    |                           |                    |                    |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------|--------------------|---------------------------|--------------------|--------------------|
|                                                   | Number-Matched Sample   |                    |                    | Exact Name-Matched Sample |                    |                    |
|                                                   | (1)                     | (2)                | (3)                | (4)                       | (5)                | (6)                |
| BJY(AC) <sub>i</sub> x Post <sub>t</sub>          | 9.20***<br>(2.57)       |                    |                    | 8.76***<br>(2.28)         |                    |                    |
| BJY(PS) <sub>i</sub> x Post <sub>t</sub>          |                         | 10.59***<br>(1.02) |                    |                           | 13.63***<br>(1.65) |                    |
| Log(Dist to BJY) <sub>i</sub> x Post <sub>t</sub> |                         |                    | -2.44***<br>(0.10) |                           |                    | -2.77***<br>(0.13) |
| Treatment Definition                              | Route Crosses AC        | Route Crosses PS   | Distance to Route  | Route Crosses AC          | Route Crosses PS   | Distance to Route  |
| Observations                                      | 105796                  | 105796             | 105796             | 57606                     | 57606              | 57606              |
| Year FEs                                          | ✓                       | ✓                  | ✓                  | ✓                         | ✓                  | ✓                  |
| Polling Station FEs                               | ✓                       | ✓                  | ✓                  | ✓                         | ✓                  | ✓                  |
| Number of Clusters (AC)                           | 224                     | 57300              | 57300              | 205                       | 34467              | 34467              |
| Mean of DV                                        | 41.1                    | 41.1               | 41.1               | 41.25                     | 41.25              | 41.25              |

Notes: \*p<0.1; \*\*p<0.05; \*\*\*p<0.01. Treatment is defined at the assembly constituency (AC) level in Columns 1 and 4 (SEs clustered at AC level), at the polling station (PS) level in Columns 2 and 5 (clustered at PS level), and as a continuous measure (log distance to the yatra) in Columns 3 and 6 (also clustered at PS level).

As a robustness test, we apply a method developed by Butts (2023), which does not assume that the effect changes linearly as we move away from the yatra route. The method divides the sample into distance quantiles and the effect is then estimated non-parametrically within each bin by comparing units before and after treatment. The estimated effect from the most distant bin is subtracted from the others to normalize the results.

Matched Sample.

<sup>11</sup>The percent of treated polling stations is 0.82% in the Number-Matched Sample and 0.78% in the Exact Name-Matched Sample.

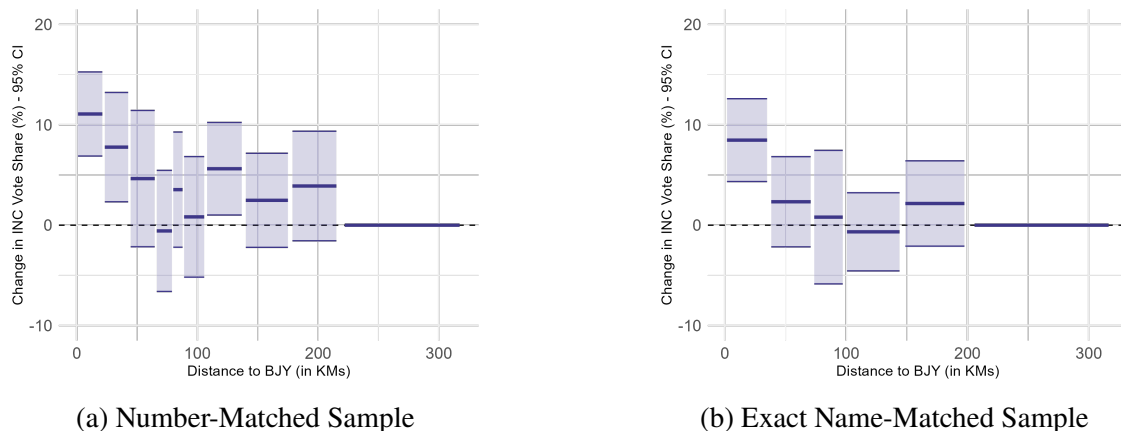


Figure 4: The effect of distance on INC vote share

The results from this analysis are visualized in Figure 4. The figure reveals that the positive effects of the yatra on the INC vote share are concentrated within approximately 50 kilometers of the yatra route. We interpret this finding as suggesting that the effect of the yatra is likely to come from some direct interaction with the march. Across all of our analysis, our design assumes that there is something critical about experiencing the yatra, beyond just hearing about it more broadly. If we believe that news about the yatra reached the country as a whole, then each design estimates the impact of a more direct experience with the yatra.

## Evidence for Why Leader Marches Work for the Opposition

Our results demonstrate that the leader march by Rahul Gandhi increased the INC's vote share in a limited way, ultimately mattering for elections that were temporally proximate, geographically close to the yatra route, and for the party organizing the yatra itself. Our theoretical argument highlights that leader marches may work for opposition parties facing populists because they address several key challenges they experience. To understand how this works for the yatra, we present evidence from interviews with twenty Congress party leaders and workers, civil society organizations, and voters, primarily in Karnataka, seven months after the election, alongside additional quantitative analysis. We discuss the interview methodology and limitations in Appendix I. The evidence highlights that leader marches allow the opposition to counter the narrative of being elite, gain visibility in a pro-incumbent environment, and demonstrate electoral viability.

## Countering the Elite Narrative

Interview evidence suggests that the yatra weakened Congress's elite image by making Rahul Gandhi's engagement with ordinary citizens visible and personally costly. During Modi's rise, the party used populist rhetoric to portray Congress as elite, while the BJP was portrayed as connected with the masses (Varshney, Ayyangar and Swaminathan 2021; Leidig and Mudde 2023; Naseemullah and Chhibber 2024). Modi's emphasis on his humble origins contrasted with the opposition's dynastic politics. In interviews, voters suggested that the yatra played a key role in challenging the narrative of Gandhi and the Congress as elite. One voter described his effort to connect: "Rahul Gandhi walked and listened to our problems."<sup>12</sup> Other voters highlighted that it was impactful to "see a party leader walking and doing this hardship"<sup>13</sup> and that "everyday when Rahul Gandhi walked people were thinking whether he would have the capacity to do the entire thing and he then he did."<sup>14</sup> One Congress worker said that "the yatra showed people that [he] was not just inheriting power." Politicians regularly criticized Gandhi as an ineffective leader and often derided as "Pappu." In places that experienced the yatra, voters claimed that "fewer people would refer to Rahul Gandhi as Pappu" stating that they "could no longer attack him like that after he walked across the entire country to meet them."<sup>15</sup>

## Gaining Visibility in a Pro-Incumbent Environment

The government's crackdown on independent news and journalists, along with efforts to centralize ownership of media companies, created an environment where the opposition would struggle to break through (Bhat 2023; Tudor 2023). The yatra provided an opportunity to gain coverage and engage voters directly, even in the pro-incumbent environment. Party workers highlighted that a diverse set of media covered Congress during the yatra. One member of the Congress team explained that "the alternative media started covering the yatra because the mainstream media was not covering it as well" and this "created a buzz" in which "people viewed Congress as different

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<sup>12</sup> Author interview with voter. January 8, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

<sup>13</sup> Author interview with voter. January 8, 2024. Bangalore Urban District

<sup>14</sup> Author interview with voter. January 9, 2024. Mandya District

<sup>15</sup> Author interview with Congress team member. January 10, 2024. Mysore District.

than before.”<sup>16</sup> The spectacle of the yatra further boosted voters’ interest, prompting many to seek out more information.

One observable implication of this would be increased political interest in topics related to the yatra. We test this using data from Google Trends, which researchers use to capture average internet search patterns among defined populations over time and space (Dancy and Fariss 2024). We examine the dynamic treatment effect of the yatra entering a state on political interest in a search topic using an event study for staggered adoption of the treatment (Callaway and Sant’Anna 2021). Figure 5 reports how searches related to Bharat Jodo Yatra, Rahul Gandhi, Indian National Congress, Narendra Modi, and Bharatiya Janata Party changed in the days leading up to and after the entry of the yatra into the particular state (Callaway and Sant’Anna 2021). In Appendix F we describe the data collection process, analysis choices, and robustness to alternative models.

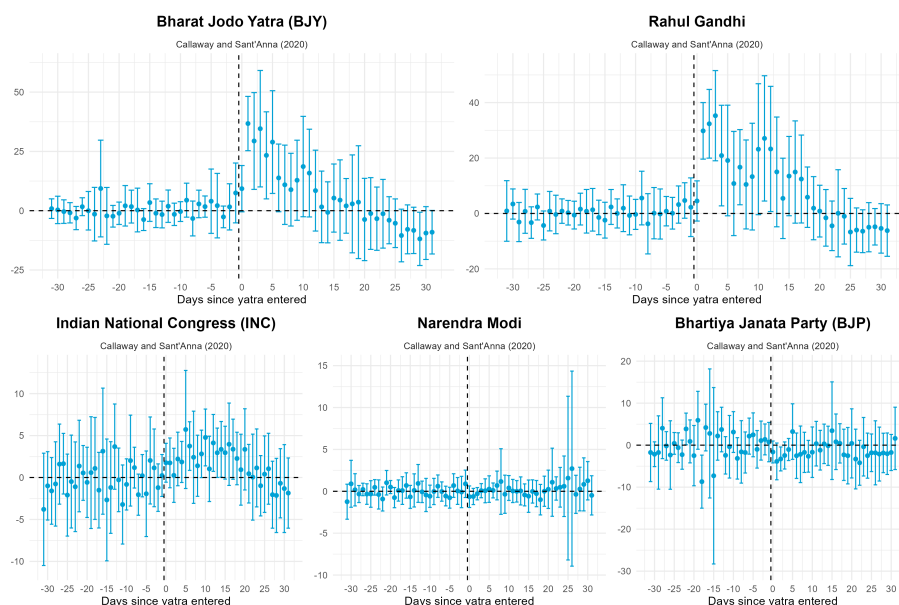


Figure 5: Impacts of BJY on Google Search Outcomes

We observed a large increase in search interest for the Bharat Jodo Yatra and Rahul Gandhi, and a smaller increase for the Indian National Congress in the days following the yatra’s entry. For each of these terms, interest levels return to pre-yatra baselines approximately 15–20 days after the yatra. We find no impact of the yatra on political interest in Narendra Modi or the BJP. We interpret

<sup>16</sup>Author interview with Congress team member. January 7, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

these findings as evidence that the yatra generated increased demand for information about the movement, the leader, and the party, despite the challenges traditionally faced by the opposition in a pro-incumbent media environment.

## **Demonstrating Electoral Viability**

The yatra improved Congress's perception of viability, despite the tilt in the electoral playing field. Increasing deference of the Election Commission to the executive (Vaishnav 2024a), reduced transparency in election financing through the use of electoral bonds (Vaishnav 2024b), and legal troubles for regional opposition leaders contributed to voter perceptions that incumbent victory was inevitable and opposition viability was low.

Interviews with voters in areas that experienced the yatra revealed how it changed the discourse around Congress, making the party appear more viable. One voter described how on a “mass level the impression of the party went up” and that “people seemed more likely to accept the Congress.”<sup>17</sup> This perception was shared by Congress party workers as well, a local Congress party worker in Mandya district, Karnataka, where the yatra passed, described how party membership increased: “after the yatra the members doubled<sup>18</sup>, especially we had many youth joining the party.”<sup>19</sup>

Improved perceptions of viability were also linked to the view that the yatra presented the Congress party as a united front against the incumbent. For example, in Karnataka, INC workers highlighted how two senior Congress leaders representing different factions within the party walked together hand-in-hand with Rahul Gandhi during the yatra, which “neutralized allegations of infighting in the Congress.”<sup>20</sup> In fact, a large poster of Rahul Gandhi walking hand in hand with these leaders was still displayed outside the Congress office building 15 months after the yatra had left Karnataka. The yatra showed that the party was united and internal factions would not limit its viability, especially considering the history of factional politics in the Congress (Brass 1965).

By helping to build party organization in areas where the yatra passed, it also increased

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<sup>17</sup>Author interview with Congress team member. January 9, 2024. Mandya District.

<sup>18</sup>We were unable to verify this but it reflects a perception that party elites noticed an increase in membership

<sup>19</sup>Author interview with Congress team member. January 9, 2024. Mandya District

<sup>20</sup>Author interview with Congress team member. January 8, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

Congress's visibility and viability. One member of Gandhi's team highlighted that the yatra provided party workers with an opportunity to "interact with Rahul Gandhi and get pictures with him" contributing to "cadre-based enthusiasm" where "the workers felt like this was the moment for the party."<sup>21</sup> This reinvigorated party organization could be expected to contribute to greater mobilization. One observable implication is an increase in election activity in yatra constituencies in the lead-up to the 2024 elections.

Using data on campaign rallies by the BJP (led by Narendra Modi or Home Minister Amit Shah) and the INC (led by Rahul Gandhi or his sister Priyanka Gandhi), we examine whether yatra constituencies hosted more general INC rallies in the 2024 campaign period.<sup>22</sup> The data on rallies during the 2024 elections are at the parliamentary constituency level, so we examine whether the share of rallies differs across yatra and non-yatra PCs. Figure 6 shows that BJT constituencies had almost double the share of Congress rallies (35%) compared to non-BJT constituencies (18%) ahead of the 2024 national elections (this difference is significant,  $p = 0.006$ ). There is no significant difference for the BJP. Because the yatra is not randomly assigned, a natural interpretation is that yatra constituencies were places where Congress was electorally strong, leading *both* to their selection for the yatra and the subsequent 2024 election rallies. One way to try to address this is examining if the difference in 2024 rallies persists in a sample of places where INC perceived itself as electorally strong. To do this, we subset to only places where INC contested in 2024. These represent the places that they did not give up to their alliance partners in 2024 indicating their strength in these areas. Among the places where INC contested, Figure 6 shows that yatra constituencies had a higher share of 2024 rallies compared to non-yatra constituencies (difference = 16 percentage points,  $p = 0.03$ ). Even in this subset we do not find differences for BJP rallies. Recognizing the caveats of this descriptive analysis, there is some suggestive evidence that the organizational capacity built during the yatra may have helped facilitate future rally mobilization even when accounting for INC strength.

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<sup>21</sup> Author interview with Congress team member. January 7, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

<sup>22</sup> The location of rallies was collected by a researcher in India and is described in the [Times of India](#).

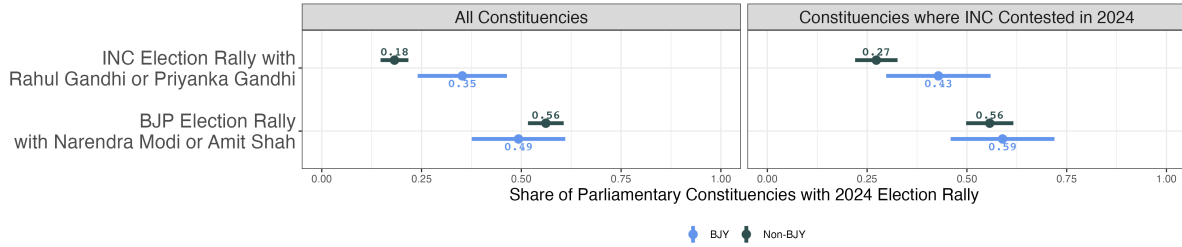


Figure 6: BJP and Congress Election Campaign Rallies in BJY and non-BJY Constituencies

## How Participation in Leader Marches Impacts Voters

We now examine the individual-level dynamics of leader marches through an original telephone survey of 3,510 citizens in Karnataka and Madhya Pradesh in January 2024, over a year after the yatra. We stratified the sample on places that the yatra did and did not cross, allowing us to obtain enough respondents who could have participated directly in the yatra. We use post-stratification weights provided by the public opinion survey firm to achieve representativeness on age, gender, education, income, social group, and rurality for each state in all of our analyses. The sample relies on individuals who own a phone and are regularly surveyed as part of the survey firm’s political surveys, suggesting that they may be more politically aware than an average Indian citizen. In Appendix H we provide details on the survey protocol, sample, and questionnaire.

### Participants of the Yatra

Figure 7 shows the demographic and political characteristics of yatra participants compared to non-participants. Overall, 24% of respondents reported participating in the yatra in some way. Appendix Table H.1 provides supporting evidence for the validity of this self-reported measure by showing that respondents located farther from the yatra route were significantly less likely to report participating in the march. Although this pattern is consistent with actual opportunities for participation, the measure remains self-reported and should therefore be interpreted with caution. Moreover, because the sample consists of phone owners who regularly participate in political surveys, respondents may be more politically engaged than the broader population.

We do not observe significant differences in gender, age, income, and education between yatra

participants and non-participants. This suggests that leader marches are not confined to particular voter demographics but rather have a broad-ranging appeal. We do, however, find that rural respondents made up a greater share of yatra participants, likely due to the higher coverage of rural areas and the spectacle of a yatra in these places. In terms of social groups, yatra participants were slightly more likely to include individuals from Scheduled Castes and Tribes; however, there were no significant differences for other social groups.

Looking at the party that voters reported supporting in 2019, which respondents were asked about earlier in the survey, we can understand the political reach of the yatra. Congress voters made up a larger share of yatra participants (55%) than non-participants (28%), while BJP voters made up a lower share of yatra participants (40%) than non-participants (60%). Notably, 17% of respondents who reported voting for the BJP in 2019 participated in the yatra, suggesting that leader marches can extend beyond core supporters to engage potential swing voters. At the same time, among Congress supporters, 39% participated in the yatra. This engagement across both groups suggests that leader marches can assist opposition parties in reaching both core and swing voters.

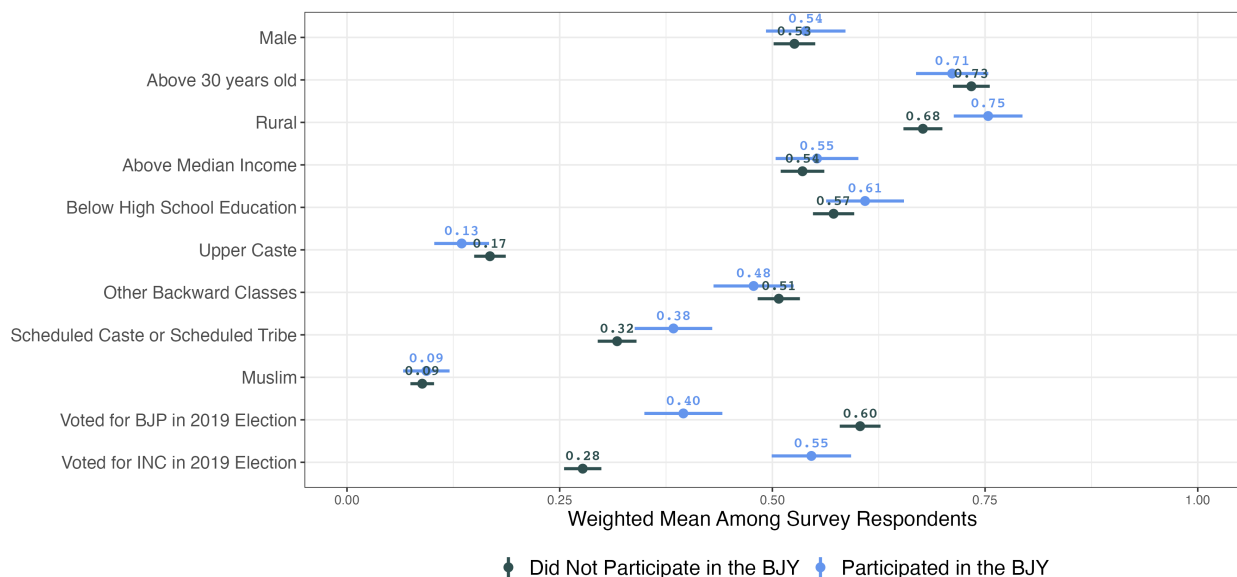


Figure 7: Demographic Characteristics of Yatra Participants

## **Yatra Participation and Political Attitudes: A Correlational Analysis**

Through a cross-sectional analysis of the survey, we examine how reported participation in the yatra is associated with differences in individual perceptions, political engagement, and voting behavior. More details on the survey questions are included in Appendix H. In Figure 8, we present the associations for each outcome variable across four samples of the survey data. First, across the full sample of all respondents, we find that participation in the yatra was associated with improved perceptions of Congress and Rahul Gandhi, increased engagement with the INC, and discourse about Rahul Gandhi. We find small and insignificant associations between yatra participation on similar outcomes related to the BJP. In terms of voting, yatra participants are more likely to report having voted for the INC in the 2023 state elections, less likely to report having voted for the BJP in both elections, and more likely to vote for the Congress today. We find consistent patterns among respondents who voted for the BJP in 2019 and those who voted for Congress in 2019. Among INC voters, the effect sizes are positive but smaller in magnitude, likely because these voters already held favorable views of the party and were predisposed to support it.

To further isolate the relationship between direct participation and longer-term impacts, we restrict the sample to only those respondents in assembly constituencies through which the yatra passed and compare participants with non-participants. The effects remain strong and statistically significant, suggesting that participation itself, rather than merely being in a yatra-visited area, drives longer-term change in attitudes and behavior. This is consistent with earlier findings from polling station-level data, where more granular definitions of “treatment” that may capture participation yielded stronger effects than broader constituency-level classifications. In Appendix H, we demonstrate the robustness of these results.

One concern with this analysis is that respondents may have a general disposition to overreport political engagement, perhaps due to social desirability bias. However, we only observe positive associations between reported participation and outcomes related to the INC and Rahul Gandhi, and not the BJP and Narendra Modi. Another concern is that general loyalty to Congress drives respondents to report yatra participation and attitudinal changes toward Congress and Rahul Gandhi.

However, when we restrict the sample to respondents who report voting for the BJP in 2019, the associations persist.

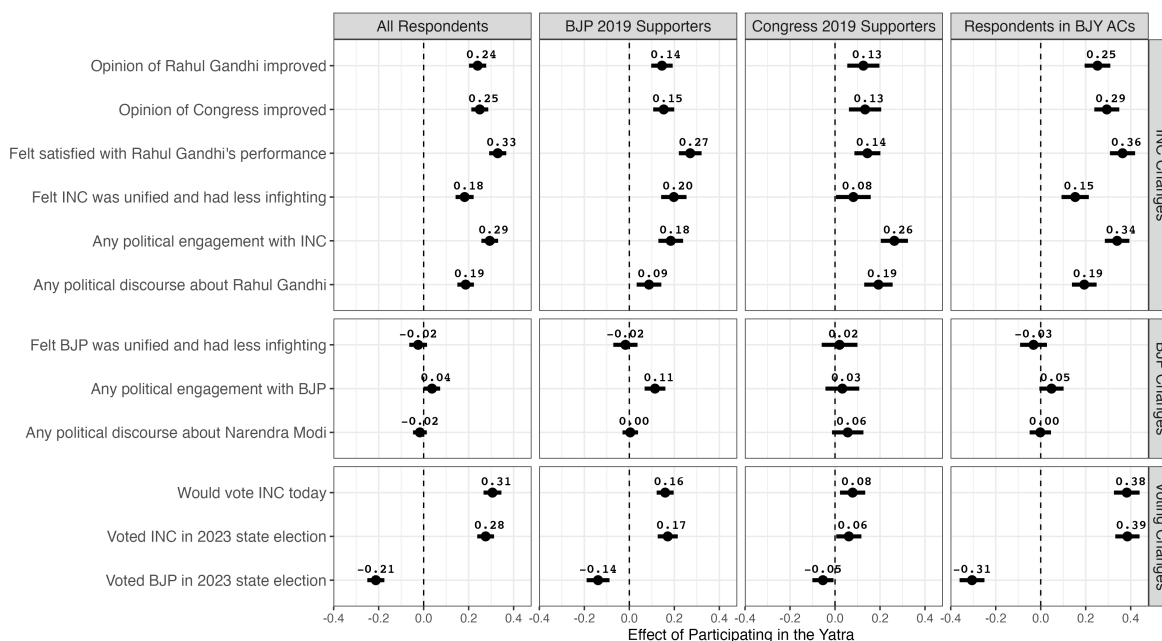


Figure 8: Relationship between Participating in the Yatra and Political Outcomes

Overall, we interpret all associations as descriptive and best read in the context of our existing observational evidence. The descriptive results suggest that participation in the yatra is not demographically constrained. Moreover, participation in the BJY had lasting impacts on voter perceptions, engagement, and vote choice, highlighting the crucial role of direct connections with leader marches.

## Conclusion

Elections remain the principal mechanism for removing populist incumbents, yet opposition parties often compete under severe informational and organizational disadvantages. This paper shows that extraordinary campaigning, like leader marches, can partially offset those disadvantages, although their effects remain geographically and temporally limited. Populists frame the opposition as out of touch with voters, shape the environment to make it difficult for them to break through to voters, and influence the electoral space to present them as nonviable, given the populists' dominance. In the face of these challenges, opposition leaders often adopt leader marches to try to

make electoral inroads against a populist at the ballot box.

Opposition parties across contexts have taken this strategy in response to populists, especially those engaging in democratic erosion. In 2017, in Turkey, Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu led the Justice March against backsliding by the Erdoğan regime. In 2020, in Tanzania, Freeman Mbowe led a walking rally for the Chadema party against the ruling CCM party. In 2025, in Hungary, Peter Magyar led the One Million Steps for Peace and National Unity march in response to democratic backsliding by Orbán. And while political commentators often suggest that these efforts could have an impact on the opposition's prospects, a comprehensive examination of this form of party-voter interaction is lacking.

We examine the impact of these leader marches by focusing on Congress Party Leader Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra. We find that the yatra increased Congress's vote share, but these effects were concentrated in elections temporally proximate to the yatra, in places spatially nearby to the yatra route, and for the party that was at the center of the yatra. Interviews and additional descriptive analysis reveal that the campaign countered the narrative of Congress as an elite party, allowed the opposition to break through in a pro-incumbent environment, and improved perceptions of the party's viability. Individual-level survey evidence shows that reported participation in the yatra was associated with improved perceptions and engagement with the opposition (and not the ruling party) one year later, highlighting that interacting with the march was crucial to its impact.

The findings should also be interpreted in the context of the Congress Party's electoral performance in the 2024 general elections. The election marked the first time in 10 years that the ruling BJP did not win an outright majority without the support of its alliance partners. The Congress party performed better than expected for a range of reasons, such as their ability to form a wide-ranging alliance with regional parties, their new ideological pitch with a bent toward justice and democratic legitimacy, their management of the internal party organization and caste-based distribution of nominations, and their effective populist appeals to the middle class (Verma and Pratikshit 2024; Chhibber 2024; Aiyar and Sircar 2025; Verniers 2025). This paper demonstrates that the Bharat Jodo Yatra also played a unique role in improving Congress's electoral performance

in the general elections in states where Congress was the key party in the INDIA alliance.

Zooming out from India, the findings suggest that leader marches can help the opposition in challenging a populist incumbent electorally. Recent work on the success of Peter Magyar in Hungary highlights the role of his grassroots efforts and countryside tours in the victory against Orban (Folsz 2026). However, this tactic is not a panacea. The effectiveness of leader marches is both geographically and temporally constrained, and they are less impactful in areas where the campaigning party is not the primary opposition face. Importantly, increasing the frequency or expanding the reach of such campaigns does not necessarily enhance their effectiveness. Instead, their influence may lie partly in the fact that they are extraordinary, costly, and a spectacle.

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# Online Appendix for *Leader Marches as an Opposition Electoral Strategy*

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## A Additional Case Context

### A.1 Congress Decline and the Rise of the BJP

The Indian National Congress was founded in 1885 with the goal of demanding representation in the government for educated Indians (Kumar 2024). The initial decades of the Congress focused on an “intellectual agitation” to articulate its demands and goals (Kothari 1964). By the 1920s and 1930s, the party had transformed into “a mass movement with depth and traditions,” a shift largely driven by Gandhi’s grassroots mobilization efforts that united citizens across ethnic and regional lines (Kothari 1964; Kumar 2024; Bhavnani and Jha 2014).

Scholars have long characterized India’s party system around the electoral centrality of the Congress Party since Independence (Yadav 1999; Vaishnav and Hintson 2019). In the two decades following 1947, Congress functioned as a “party of consensus,” despite its dependence on particular social coalitions across states (Kothari 1964; Weiner 1967). A fragmented opposition enabled Congress to dominate both national and state elections during this period (Vaishnav and Hintson 2019; Yadav 1999). The Congress party’s primary competition was not from the opposition parties but from factions within the party itself (Brass 1965; Kochanek 1968), which the party was able to manage well in this period (Weiner 1967; Kothari 1964).

From 1967-1989, the INC began to lose out at the state level but retained dominance nationally, even recovering after its defeat following Indira Gandhi’s moment of authoritarianism during the Emergency (Yadav 1999). During this phase, the Congress Party increasingly came to depend on its control over state institutions to distribute patronage, marking a departure from its earlier identity as a mass movement (Wilkinson 2007; Chhibber 2001). For example, Chhibber (2001) notes how Congress party workers became attuned to the role of resources in mobilizing votes, making their motivations for joining the party more reflective of self-interest than of influencing policy. Wilkinson (2007) notes that as competition intensified, clientelism became both more extensive and more systematic.

Between 1989 and 2014, the rise of caste-based, religious, and class mobilization disrupted Congress’s status as “the single pole around which politics revolved” (Vaishnav and Hintson 2019) and prominent regional parties gained more power (Ziegfeld 2016). A confluence of factors contributed to Congress’s decline: ideological incoherence (Chhibber and Verma 2018; Hasan 2022), weakened organizational structure (Kothari 1964; Tudor and Ziegfeld 2019; Hasan 2012), persistent intra-party factionalism (Brass 1965), rising opposition coordination (Tudor and Ziegfeld 2019), sociopolitical shifts induced by the Green Revolution (Dasgupta 2018), and the rise of new political identities (Jaffrelot and Kumar 2012). In 2014 and 2019, Congress suffered two consecutive major losses to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) at the national level, ushering in the fourth party system with the BJP at the center of politics (Vaishnav and Hintson 2019; Jaffrelot and Verniers

2020).

## **A.2 The Bharat Jodo Yatra**

The yatra covered approximately 20–25 kilometers each day. Interviews with Congress party workers who joined for portions of the yatra provided an overview of the daily schedule. Rahul Gandhi and those walking with him typically awoke around 5:00 AM, held a morning flag-hoisting ceremony with the national anthem, began walking around 6:00 AM, and completed a 10–12 km morning leg before resting for lunch. The midday break was used for meetings with local organizations, civil society groups, and community leaders to discuss state-specific concerns. A second walking session began in the late afternoon, followed by evening corner meetings or public rallies before the day concluded around 8:00 PM. Citizens could join the march for a few minutes, several kilometers, or multiple days, and many local residents lined roadsides to greet participants, raise local grievances, or participate in public meetings. The extended walking format created repeated opportunities for informal conversations, small-group discussions, and symbolic displays of engagement with the leader that would have been difficult to replicate through conventional rallies.

## **B Data**

### **B.1 Bharat Jodo Yatra Route**

The Indian National Congress formally announced the Bharat Jodo Yatra on August 23, 2022. The official social media account (Facebook and X/Twitter) of Bharat Jodo Yatra released a schedule of daily on-foot journeys by Rahul Gandhi. We manually mapped this daily schedule from September 7, 2022, to January 30, 2023, every day. The Yatra covered approximately 20 kilometers per day, with five to six designated stops each day. Because the yatra followed major highways, we connected these stops to construct a continuous route of over 4,000 kilometers, representing the Bharat Jodo Yatra. To ensure accuracy, we triangulated this route using three sources: contemporaneous newspaper reports, official social media feeds from the Congress party, and the live stream of the Yatra on YouTube, to account for any changes based on what social media had initially reported. We then validated our constructed route with the Indian National Congress. Figure 1 shows the BJY route. We use this route to identify “treated” electoral constituencies or places where the yatra crossed. We identify treatment at the assembly constituency (AC) level for our main analysis. This is the smallest, electorally meaningful unit for party-based electoral politics.<sup>23</sup>

### **B.2 Congress Electoral Performance**

Our goal is to examine the impact of the yatra on Congress’ electoral performance in the subsequent state and national elections. At the national level, India uses a parliamentary system

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<sup>23</sup>Assembly constituencies are state-level electoral districts.

where voters elect members of the Lok Sabha, the lower house of Parliament, every 5 years. The party or coalition with the most seats forms the government and its leader becomes the Prime Minister. At the state level, the same electoral rules apply as voters elect Members of the Legislative Assembly with the majority party or coalition forming the state government and determining the Chief Minister. Both state and national elections use first-past-the-post electoral rules.

During the Bharat Jodo Yatra, Rahul Gandhi traveled across India between September 2022 and January 2023. In the period following the Yatra, state assembly elections were held in Karnataka (May 2023), Telangana, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh (all in December 2023), and Andhra Pradesh (May 2024). National parliamentary elections were conducted between April and June 2024.<sup>24</sup>

**State Assembly Election:** The state assembly election results data for the states of Karnataka (2008, 2013, 2018), Madhya Pradesh (2008, 2013, 2018), Rajasthan (2008, 2013, 2018), Telangana (2009, 2014, 2018), and Andhra Pradesh (2009, 2014, 2019) are accessed from the Trivedi Centre for Political Data (TCPD) (Agarwal et al. 2022).<sup>25</sup> For the most recent elections, Karnataka (2023), Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Telangana (2023), and Andhra Pradesh (2024), we scraped official results from the Election Commission of India. We restrict our analysis to elections held after 2008, as earlier results are not comparable due to changes in constituency boundaries following delimitation.

**National Election:** We collect national election results at the assembly constituency level.<sup>26</sup> There are 543 Parliamentary constituencies in India and within these there are about 5-9 assembly constituencies (AC). Using AC-level results for the national elections allows us more fine-grained data to understand the impact of the yatra. The AC level results for the Lok Sabha election give us votes polled by each candidate at the AC level from TCPD for the years 2009, 2014, and 2019 (Agarwal et al. 2022). For AC level results for 2024, we scrape, OCR and manually code the vote share for the Congress candidate for each assembly constituency from the election commission website for each state.<sup>27</sup> As with our state-level analysis, we limit our focus to elections conducted after 2008 due to changes in constituency boundaries following delimitation.

## C Descriptive Details of Yatra and non-Yatra ACs

Table C.1 shows the differences between treated (BJY) and control constituencies on a range of outcomes related to the state election that happened before the yatra (the 2018 election for

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<sup>24</sup>Between the yatra and the 2024 national elections, there were also state elections in Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, and Odisha; however, the yatra did not cross through any of these states.

<sup>25</sup>For the state elections analysis, we standardize the years to 2008, 2013, 2018, and 2023. For the state of Telangana, the elections are 2009, 2014, 2018, and 2023. In all figures and tables, we will use 2008 for the 2009 election and 2013 for 2014 to keep the consistency with the other three states. For the state of Andhra Pradesh, the elections are 2009, 2014, 2019, 2024. In all figures and tables, we move these back by one year to allow for consistency in plotting.

<sup>26</sup>We do not have AC level data for the following states: Jammu and Kashmir, Assam, Manipur, and Arunachal Pradesh.

<sup>27</sup>We use the Form 20 polling station results to determine the vote share for Congress in each AC.

Karnataka, Telangana, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh and the 2019 election in Andhra Pradesh). Table C.2 shows the differences between treated (BJY) and control constituencies on a range of outcomes related to the 2019 national elections. These balance tables highlight that the yatra was more likely to occur in places where Congress had some footing in the prior election.

Table C.1: Balance Table: Treated and Control Constituencies in 2018 State Elections

| Variable                      | BJY - Treated | Control | Difference | p-Value |
|-------------------------------|---------------|---------|------------|---------|
| Number of Candidates          | 13.333        | 13.431  | -0.10      | 0.88    |
| Number of Female Candidates   | 1.149         | 1.055   | 0.10       | 0.48    |
| Share of INC Contesting       | 0.931         | 0.973   | -0.04      | 0.13    |
| Share of INC Winning          | 0.322         | 0.330   | -0.01      | 0.87    |
| INC Vote Share                | 35.286        | 31.585  | 3.70       | 0.05    |
| Share of BJP Contesting       | 1.000         | 0.997   | 0.00       | 0.08    |
| Share of BJP Winning          | 0.299         | 0.303   | -0.00      | 0.93    |
| BJP Vote Share                | 29.691        | 27.655  | 2.04       | 0.34    |
| Turnout                       | 74.70         | 76.64   | -1.94      | 0.10    |
| Share Reserved for SC/ST      | 0.276         | 0.273   | 0.00       | 0.96    |
| Effective Number of Parties   | 2.578         | 2.690   | -0.11      | 0.04    |
| Distance to BGY route (in KM) | 8.115         | 196.937 | -188.82    | 0.00    |

*Note:* Assembly Elections in the state of Karnataka, Telangana, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh took place in 2018 while in 2019 in Andhra Pradesh. P-values are from Welch two-sample t-tests.

## D Robustness and Additional Results

### D.1 State Elections

In this section, we present a series of robustness and additional results related to the state election analysis. Table D.1 shows the effect of distance to the yatra on INC vote share in state elections. Table D.2 shows the effect of the yatra on Congress win in state elections.

### D.2 National Elections

In this section, we present a series of robustness and additional results related to the national election analysis. Table D.3 shows the effect of the yatra on INC vote share and likelihood of winning in the national elections, measured at the PC-level. Table D.4 shows the effect of distance to the yatra on INC vote share in national elections measured at the AC-level.

To measure if Congress was the main alliance party against the BJP we look at whether Congress contested in over 80% of the elections in the particular state in 2009-2019. This resulted in a focus on the following 22 states in the main analysis: Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Delhi, Goa, Gujarat, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Manipur, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Odisha, Puducherry, Punjab, Rajasthan, Sikkim, Telangana, Tripura, Uttar Pradesh, and Uttarakhand.

Table C.2: Balance Table: Treated and Control Constituencies in 2019 General Elections

| Variable                      | BJY - Treated | Control | Difference | p-value | Level |
|-------------------------------|---------------|---------|------------|---------|-------|
| Share of INC Winning          | 0.307         | 0.138   | 0.17       | 0.00    | AC    |
| INC Vote Share                | 35.315        | 26.680  | 8.63       | 0.00    | AC    |
| Share of BJP Winning          | 0.448         | 0.514   | -0.07      | 0.06    | AC    |
| BJP Vote Share                | 42.657        | 45.507  | -2.85      | 0.07    | AC    |
| Effective Number of Parties   | 2.446         | 2.375   | 0.07       | 0.03    | AC    |
| Distance to BJY route (in KM) | 6.552         | 558.846 | -552.29    | 0.00    | AC    |
| Number of Candidates          | 17.224        | 15.337  | 1.89       | 0.00    | PC    |
| Number of Female Candidates   | 1.349         | 1.363   | -0.01      | 0.69    | PC    |
| Share of INC Contesting       | 0.804         | 0.729   | 0.08       | 0.00    | PC    |
| Share of BJP Contesting       | 0.800         | 0.797   | 0.00       | 0.77    | PC    |
| Turnout                       | 67.149        | 65.669  | 1.48       | 0.00    | PC    |
| Share Reserved for SC/ST      | 0.223         | 0.225   | -0.00      | 0.80    | PC    |
| Distance to BJY route (in KM) | 26.557        | 485.101 | -458.54    | 0.00    | PC    |

Note: Some variables are only available at either the Assembly Constituency (AC) or Parliamentary Constituency (PC) level. The “Level” column indicates the level at which each variable is measured.

Table D.1: Effect of Distance to the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in State Elections

|                                                   | DV: Congress Vote Share |                                |                                    |                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
|                                                   | all state elections     | elections 7 months since yatra | elections 11-13 months since yatra | elections 19 months since yatra |
|                                                   | (1)                     | (2)                            | (3)                                | (4)                             |
| Log(Dist to BJY) <sub>i</sub> x Post <sub>t</sub> | -1.65***<br>(0.29)      | -1.20**<br>(0.59)              | 0.26<br>(0.32)                     | 0.37<br>(0.32)                  |
| Observations                                      | 3747                    | 891                            | 2160                               | 696                             |
| Year FEs                                          | ✓                       | ✓                              | ✓                                  | ✓                               |
| PC/AC FEs                                         | ✓                       | ✓                              | ✓                                  | ✓                               |
| Number of Clusters (AC)                           | 948                     | 224                            | 549                                | 175                             |
| Mean of DV                                        | 32.29                   | 38.38                          | 36.57                              | 11.24                           |

Notes: \*p<0.1; \*\*p<0.05; \*\*\*p<0.01. SEs clustered at the assembly constituency level. Karnataka elections were held 7 months after the yatra crossed the state, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, and Telangana elections were held 11-13 months after the yatra crossed their states, and Andhra Pradesh elections were held 19 months after the yatra crossed the state.

### D.3 Robustness of Distance Analysis for State and National

In Table D.5, we show the p-values for results for state and (AC and PC level) national elections in the main text using Conley Standard Errors with different distance cutoffs to adjust for spatial correlation, where errors are correlated across units that are geographically close to each other. Our effects are robust to this test across distance cutoffs.

## E Karnataka Polling Station Data

We provide full details on the scraping and processing of our Karnataka polling station data. Form 20 provides election results at the polling station level for all contesting candidates in India. On average, each polling station has approximately 900 voters. There were 56,994 polling stations in the 2018 Karnataka assembly election. We scrape the data for the 2018 polling station-level

Table D.2: Effect Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Win in State Elections

|                         | DV: Congress Win    |                                |                                    |                                 |
|-------------------------|---------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
|                         | all state elections | elections 7 months since yatra | elections 11-13 months since yatra | elections 19 months since yatra |
|                         | (1)                 | (2)                            | (3)                                | (4)                             |
| $BJY_i \times Post_t$   | 0.12**<br>(0.06)    | 0.18*<br>(0.10)                | 0.07<br>(0.07)                     | 0.001<br>(0.07)                 |
| Observations            | 3784                | 893                            | 2195                               | 696                             |
| Year FEs                | ✓                   | ✓                              | ✓                                  | ✓                               |
| AC FEs                  | ✓                   | ✓                              | ✓                                  | ✓                               |
| Number of Clusters (AC) | 948                 | 224                            | 549                                | 175                             |
| Mean of DV              | 0.34                | 0.47                           | 0.34                               | 0.15                            |

Notes: \* $p < 0.1$ ; \*\* $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*\* $p < 0.01$ . SEs clustered at the assembly constituency level. Karnataka elections were held 7 months after the yatra crossed the state, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, and Telangana elections were held 11-13 months after the yatra crossed their states, and Andhra Pradesh elections were held 19 months after the yatra crossed the state.

Table D.3: Effect of Yatra on INC Vote Share and Win in National Elections (PC-Level)

|                         | Vote Share: All States | Vote Share: Congress Strongholds (2009–2019) | Win: All States | Win: Congress Strongholds (2009–2019) |
|-------------------------|------------------------|----------------------------------------------|-----------------|---------------------------------------|
|                         | (1)                    | (2)                                          | (3)             | (4)                                   |
| $BJY_i \times Post_t$   | -0.55<br>(1.38)        | 0.94<br>(1.60)                               | 0.02<br>(0.03)  | 0.02<br>(0.03)                        |
| Observations            | 1598                   | 1145                                         | 4183            | 2529                                  |
| Year FEs                | ✓                      | ✓                                            | ✓               | ✓                                     |
| PC FEs                  | ✓                      | ✓                                            | ✓               | ✓                                     |
| Number of Clusters (PC) | 501                    | 317                                          | 529             | 319                                   |
| Mean of DV              | 28.93                  | 29.57                                        | 0.09            | 0.1                                   |

Notes: \* $p < 0.1$ ; \*\* $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*\* $p < 0.01$ .

results from the Karnataka Election Information System.<sup>28</sup> The website gives polling station-level votes for each candidate. We then manually mapped candidates to their political party using the state election data from TCPD. Due to some missingness, we have 54,433 polling stations in our data out of 56,994 in 2018. The data for the 2023 assembly election for the state of Karnataka is only available in PDF format on the website of the Chief Election Commissioner of Karnataka<sup>29</sup>. We scraped the PDF and OCR and then manually cleaned the data to map the candidate with their political party.<sup>30</sup> In our data, we have 47,898 out of 58,282 polling stations in 2023.

The Form 20 polling station electoral data for Karnataka for 2018 and 2023 only mentions the assembly constituency number and polling station serial number. However, the polling station numbers do not necessarily remain the same for 2018 and 2023. For example, the number of polling stations has increased by 1,288 from 2018 to 2023. To overcome this challenge, we take the most conservative path and match the polling station over time using the name of the polling station. We obtained the names of 56,653 (out of 56,994) polling stations for 2018 Form 20 from scraped the polling stations across India in 2018. The names of 58,198 (out of 58,282) polling stations for the 2023 elections were scraped from the Karnataka Election Information System.

<sup>28</sup>Karnataka Election Information, last accessed on 6th Aug 2024

<sup>29</sup>Karnataka CEO, last accessed on 6th Aug 2024

<sup>30</sup>Note that many of these websites are only accessible in India or with a VPN.

Table D.4: Effect Distance to the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in National Elections (AC-Level)

|                                                         | DV: Congress Vote Share |                     |                 |                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|---------------------|-----------------|---------------------|
|                                                         | AC: All States          | AC: Fight Inc > 0.8 | PC: All States  | PC: Fight Inc > 0.8 |
| $\text{Log}(\text{Dist to BJY})_i \times \text{Post}_t$ | -0.85***<br>(0.20)      | -1.56***<br>(0.24)  | -0.09<br>(0.53) | -0.67<br>(0.66)     |
| Observations                                            | 12328                   | 9421                | 1598            | 1145                |
| Year FEs                                                | TRUE                    | TRUE                | TRUE            | TRUE                |
| Unit FEs                                                | TRUE                    | TRUE                | TRUE            | TRUE                |
| Number of Clusters                                      | 3743                    | 2576                | 501             | 317                 |
| Mean of DV                                              | 30.66                   | 31.61               | 28.93           | 29.57               |

Notes: \*p<0.1; \*\*p<0.05; \*\*\*p<0.01.

Table D.5: P-values Different Cutoff Distances (Conley Standard Errors)

| Distance Cutoff in KMs | P-Value         |                      |                                 |                    |                    |                           |                    |                          |
|------------------------|-----------------|----------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------|--------------------|---------------------------|--------------------|--------------------------|
|                        | All (VS)<br>(1) | Karnataka(VS)<br>(2) | Telangana, MP, Raj. (VS)<br>(3) | Andhra (VS)<br>(4) | All (LS-AC)<br>(5) | LS Strongholds(AC)<br>(6) | All (LS-PC)<br>(7) | LS-PC Strongholds<br>(8) |
| 5                      | 0               | 0.0402               | 0.4178                          | 0.2533             | 0.0015             | 0                         | 0.8626             | 0.0368                   |
| 10                     | 0               | 0.0319               | 0.4913                          | 0.2567             | 0.0195             | 0                         | 0.8640             | 0.0407                   |
| 25                     | 0.0010          | 0.0275               | 0.5752                          | 0.3141             | 0.1442             | 0.0049                    | 0.8773             | 0.0770                   |
| 30                     | 0.0020          | 0.0085               | 0.5920                          | 0.3625             | 0.1693             | 0.0077                    | 0.8819             | 0.0841                   |
| 40                     | 0.0046          | 0.0176               | 0.6179                          | 0.4027             | 0.2130             | 0.0138                    | 0.8894             | 0.0873                   |
| 50                     | 0.0091          | 0.0158               | 0.6313                          | 0.4209             | 0.2491             | 0.0218                    | 0.8947             | 0.0998                   |
| 75                     | 0.0229          | 0.0345               | 0.6427                          | 0.3513             | 0.3188             | 0.0456                    | 0.9068             | 0.1527                   |
| 100                    | 0.0323          | 0.0211               | 0.6350                          | 0.1810             | 0.3653             | 0.0627                    | 0.9168             | 0.1852                   |

We fuzzy-match polling stations using the names for 2018 and 2023. We iterate over all assembly constituencies one by one and successfully match over 50% of the polling stations. To verify our match, we look at the correlation between polling station numbers in 2018 and 2023, as only a small fraction of polling stations changed their numbers. The polling station serial number for the vast majority should remain the same. The correlation for the names matched without a single difference in a name string is 99.24% while for names matched with at most 10 character difference in the name is 97.3%. Right now, this is the most conservative approach to matching.

## F Google Trends

We collect search behavior for the following topics: Bharat Jodo Yatra, Rahul Gandhi, Indian National Congress, Narendra Modi, and Bharatiya Janata Party. These Google Trends Topics include a group of terms that share the same concept in any language. This ensures that we capture the entire search pattern on the Google platform, regardless of the language or similar wording used to search for it. Google Trends measures an interest from citizens in search terms related to the yatra, rather than evidence of media coverage. Google Trends does not provide raw search totals; instead, it offers data that has already been transformed using min-max normalization from 0 to 100. The dependent variable will take a value of 100 when the maximum ratio of BJY topic searches to all Google searches is achieved, and 0 when it is at its minimum. We collect daily data for all Indian states from September 6, 2022, to January 31, 2023, from one day before the BJY

began to one day after it ended.

We examine the effect of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Google searches using an event study at the state-day level. This analysis tests the dynamic treatment effects of the yatra entering a state on political interest in a search topic. When the yatra entered a state, we observed a large increase in search interest for the Bharat Jodo Yatra and Rahul Gandhi, and a smaller increase for the Indian National Congress in the days following entry. For each of these terms, interest levels return to pre-yatra baselines approximately 15–20 days after the yatra.

Table F.1 shows the difference-in-difference effect of the yatra entering a state on daily Google trends searches.

Table F.1: Effect Bharat Jodo Yatra on Daily Google Search Rate

|                       | DV: Search Popularity Index |                    |                   |                |                 |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------|-------------------|----------------|-----------------|
|                       | BJY                         | Rahul Gandhi       | INC               | Narendra Modi  | BJP             |
|                       | (1)                         | (2)                | (3)               | (4)            | (5)             |
| $BJY_i \times Post_t$ | 46.49***<br>(6.73)          | 45.32***<br>(3.19) | 3.91***<br>(1.24) | 0.32<br>(0.70) | 2.92*<br>(1.52) |
| Observations          | 4144                        | 4144               | 4440              | 4884           | 4588            |
| State FEs             | ✓                           | ✓                  | ✓                 | ✓              | ✓               |
| Day FEs               | ✓                           | ✓                  | ✓                 | ✓              | ✓               |
| Mean of DV            | 8.65                        | 16.06              | 12.88             | 6.31           | 14.4            |

Notes: \* $p < 0.1$ ; \*\* $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*\* $p < 0.01$ . SEs clustered at the state level. The variable Post equals 1 only while the Yatra is physically present in a given state, and switches to 0 once it leaves.

Table F.2: Effect Bharat Jodo Yatra on Daily Google Search Rate (Post==1 Always)

|                       | DV: Search Popularity Index |                    |                 |                |                 |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------|-----------------|----------------|-----------------|
|                       | BJY                         | Rahul Gandhi       | INC             | Narendra Modi  | BJP             |
|                       | (1)                         | (2)                | (3)             | (4)            | (5)             |
| $BJY_i \times Post_t$ | 13.54***<br>(3.39)          | 11.77***<br>(2.97) | −0.48<br>(0.79) | 0.17<br>(0.38) | −0.79<br>(0.99) |
| Observations          | 4144                        | 4144               | 4440            | 4884           | 4588            |
| State FEs             | ✓                           | ✓                  | ✓               | ✓              | ✓               |
| Day FEs               | ✓                           | ✓                  | ✓               | ✓              | ✓               |
| Mean of DV            | 8.65                        | 16.06              | 12.88           | 6.31           | 14.4            |

Notes: \* $p < 0.1$ ; \*\* $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*\* $p < 0.01$ . SEs clustered at the state level. Here, the variable Post switches to 1 once the Yatra enters a state and remains 1 thereafter, even after it has moved on.

For the Google Trends event study in the main text, we present the results using the Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) method. Compared to other popular DiD estimators, the Callaway and

[Sant’Anna \(2021\)](#) method is particularly appropriate for analyzing the effect of Rahul Gandhi’s entry into Indian states on Google Trends popularity data due to its explicit modeling of staggered treatment timing and flexible estimation of group-time average treatment effects. Unlike two-way fixed effects (TWFE), which is known to produce biased estimates in staggered settings due to negative weighting and contamination from already-treated units, the [Callaway and Sant’Anna \(2021\)](#) approach uses only appropriate comparison groups (e.g., not-yet-treated or never-treated states) for each treated group at each time. While [did2s \(Gardner 2022\)](#) and [sunab \(Sun and Abraham 2021\)](#) correct for TWFE biases and allow dynamic estimation, they focus primarily on event-time effects and assume a homogeneous dynamic treatment path across groups. In contrast, Callaway and Sant’Anna’s method allows for treatment effect heterogeneity across both groups and time, making it better suited when different states may react differently or at different speeds to Rahul Gandhi’s entry. This makes it the most appropriate method when both staggered timing and treatment effect heterogeneity are central concerns. Still, in [Figures F.1, F.2, and F.3](#) we present the event study using alternative approaches and find similar results.

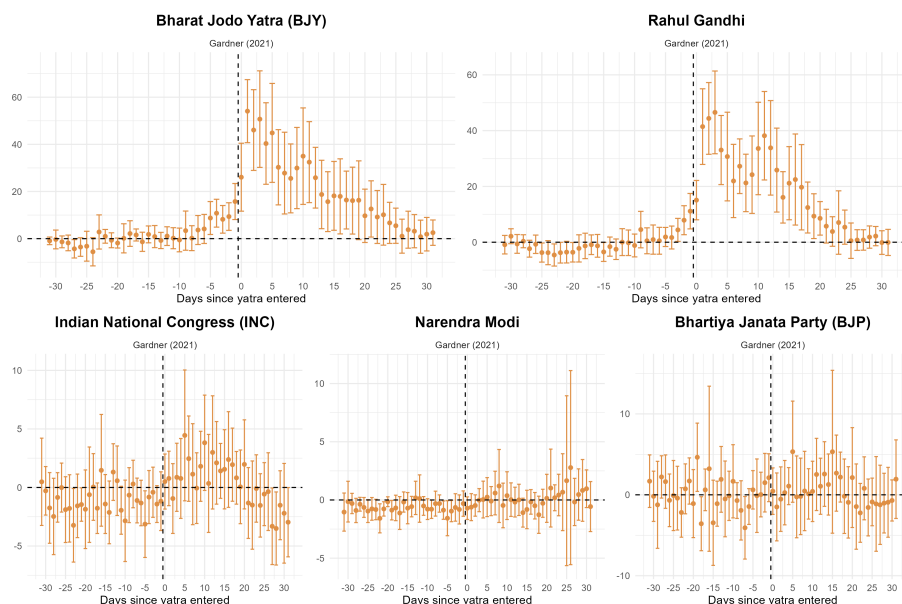


Figure F.1: Impacts of BJJ on Google Search Outcomes ([Gardner 2022](#))

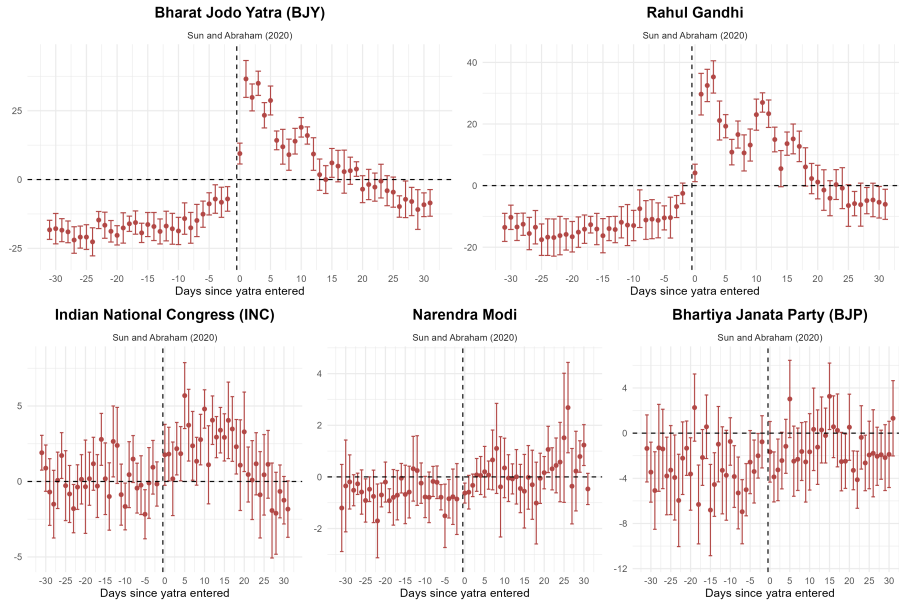


Figure F.2: Impacts of BJJ on Google Search Outcomes (Sun and Abraham 2021)

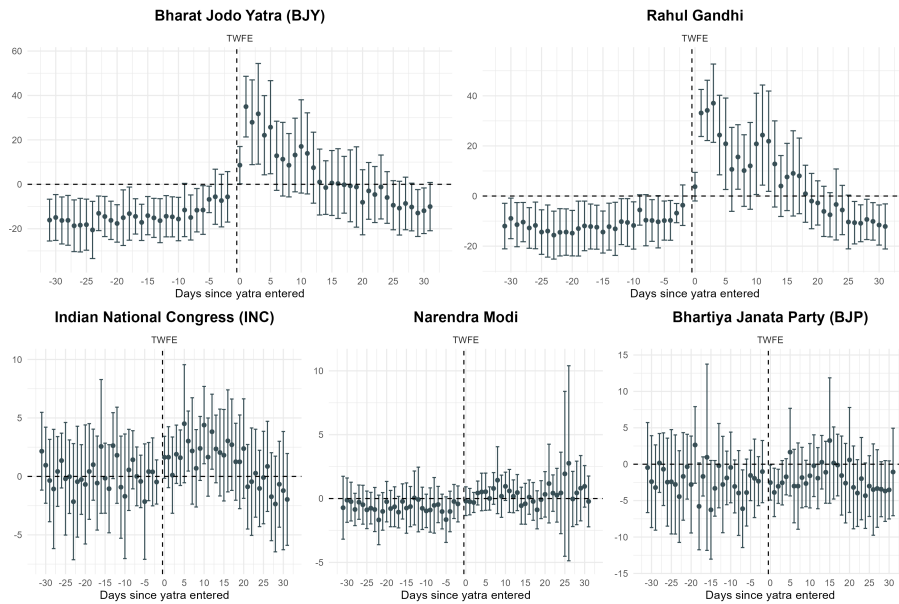


Figure F.3: Impacts of BJJ on Google Search Outcomes (TWFE)

## G Matching

### G.1 Diagnostics

To strengthen the difference-in-differences design, we construct a matched sample of treated (yatra) and control (non-yatra) assembly constituencies that are comparable on pre-treatment char-

acteristics. We match directly on the full vector of covariates using Mahalanobis-distance matching (1:1 nearest-neighbor, without replacement). We adopt this approach following [King and Nielsen \(2019\)](#), who show that matching on propensity scores can create covariate imbalance. Mahalanobis-distance matching pairs each treated constituency with the control constituency that is closest across all covariates jointly, scaling by their covariance so that correlated variables are not double-counted. The covariates that we use are the effective number of parties, reserved-seat status (general, SC, ST), 2019 INC vote share, whether the INC lost its deposit in 2019, the constituency size (total electors), and voter turnout in 2019.

In [Figure G.1](#) we show a Love plot of absolute standardized mean differences before (red) and after (green) matching, with the conventional 0.1 threshold marked. All covariates fall well below 0.1 after matching, indicating that first-moment imbalances present in the raw comparison are eliminated. [Figure G.2](#) shows the full distributional balance for a key variable that we matched on (INC 2019 Vote Share), comparing treated and control distributions before and after matching. The matched distributions align closely, confirming overlap beyond mean equivalence. Overall, the diagnostics along with the balance table in the main text confirm that the matching procedure achieved covariate balance and common support.

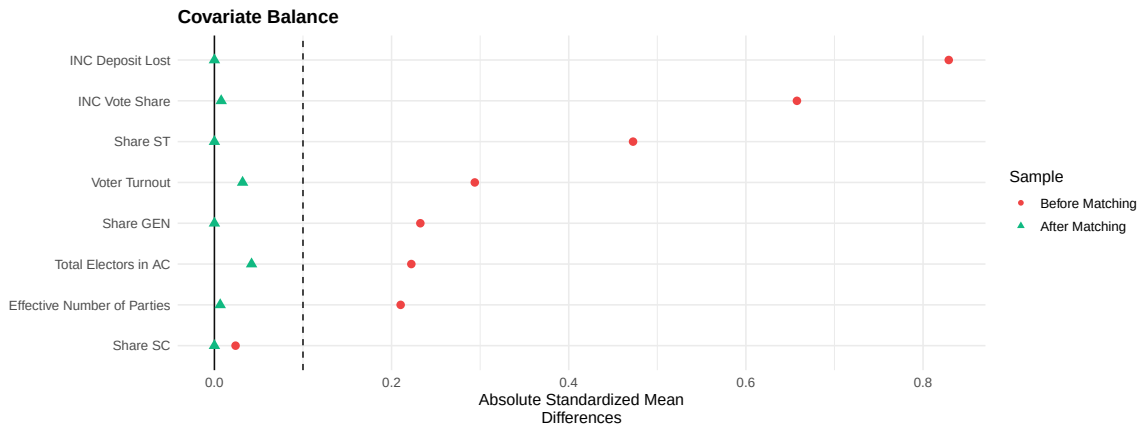


Figure G.1: Standardized Mean Differences for Covariates

## G.2 Alternative Matching Procedure Results

In addition to the Mahalanobis matching procedure in the main text, we also show that our results are robust to using propensity score matching and Mahalanobis matching within states where we only allow matched control constituencies to be selected from constituencies within the state of the treated unit. These results are reported in [Table G.1](#). The result from the main text that the effect of the yatra in the national elections was concentrated in states where Congress was the key opposition party holds across these alternative matching procedures.

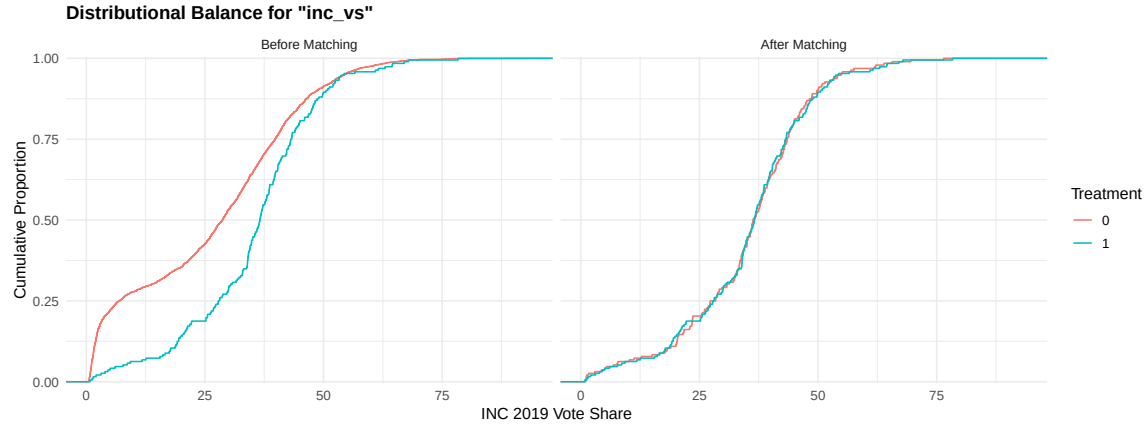


Figure G.2: Distributional Balance for INC Vote Share

Table G.1: Effect of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in National Elections (Alternate Matching Procedures)

|                         | DV: Congress Vote Share         |                                  |                                           |                                  |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
|                         | Propensity Score Matched Sample |                                  | Mahalanobis (within state) Matched Sample |                                  |
|                         | All States                      | Congress Strongholds (2009-2019) | All States                                | Congress Strongholds (2009-2019) |
|                         | (1)                             | (2)                              | (3)                                       | (4)                              |
| $BJY_t \times Post_t$   | 2.15*<br>(1.23)                 | 3.28**<br>(1.54)                 | 1.33<br>(1.09)                            | 2.59**<br>(1.31)                 |
| Observations            | 1414                            | 1061                             | 1472                                      | 1118                             |
| Year FEs                | Yes                             | Yes                              | Yes                                       | Yes                              |
| AC FEs                  | Yes                             | Yes                              | Yes                                       | Yes                              |
| Number of Clusters (AC) | 380                             | 278                              | 384                                       | 288                              |
| Mean of DV              | 37.11                           | 36.39                            | 37.17                                     | 35.72                            |

Notes: \* $p < 0.1$ ; \*\* $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*\* $p < 0.01$ . Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level.

## H Phone Survey

### H.1 Survey Methodology and Details

The survey was administered by CVoter, an Indian public opinion research firm, in January 2024, approximately fifteen months after the yatra passed through Karnataka and thirteen months after it passed through Madhya Pradesh. CVoter added the questions to regular omnibus surveys that use random digit dialing. CVoter provides post-stratification weights to achieve representativeness on age, gender, education, income, social group, and rurality for each state. In all of our analyses, we use these weights.

In Karnataka, we surveyed 420 respondents in 20 assembly constituencies where the yatra passed and 896 respondents across a random sample of 40 assembly constituencies where the yatra did not pass through. In Madhya Pradesh, we surveyed 965 respondents across 18 assembly constituencies where the yatra passed and 1,229 respondents across a random sample of 42 assembly

constituencies where the yatra did not pass through. Figure H.1 shows the ACs for which we have survey respondents. Stratifying the sample on places that the yatra did and did not cross allowed us to obtain enough respondents who could have participated directly in the yatra.

The survey was approved by [Redacted University]’s Institutional Review Board.

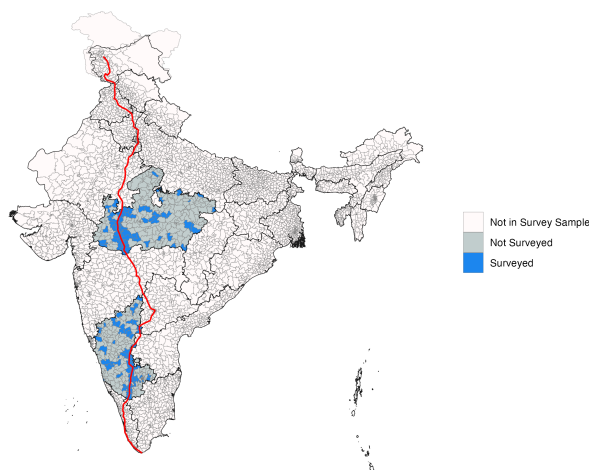


Figure H.1: Map of ACs in our Survey Data

We focus on 4 different subsets of respondents:

- All respondents
- BJP 2019 supporters: those who reported that they voted for the BJP when asked which party they supported in the 2019 Lok Sabha election
- INC 2019 supporters: those who reported that they voted for the INC when asked which party they supported in the 2019 Lok Sabha election
- BJY ACs respondents: those who were in assembly constituencies that the yatra passed through

We look at several outcome variables from the survey. Here we list each question for the outcomes.

- How has your opinion of Rahul Gandhi been in the past year - improved, stayed the same, worsened, don’t know / can’t say
- How has your opinion of the Congress Party been in the past year - improved, stayed the same, worsened, don’t know / can’t say
- How satisfied are you with the performance of Congress leader, Rahul Gandhi in the past year - very much satisfied, satisfied to some extent, not at all satisfied, don’t know / can’t say

- In the past year, did you feel that the INC was unified and had less infighting - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Any political engagement with INC (did at least one of the following):
  - Receive any political messages from Congress by phone - yes, no, don't know, refused
  - Attend a Congress political meeting or election rally - yes, no, don't know, refused
  - Get contacted by a party worker from Congress - yes, no, don't know, refused
  - Attended a rally by a state leader - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Any political discourse about Rahul Gandhi (did at least one of the following)
  - Heard Rahul Gandhi discussed on television/phone - yes, no, don't know, refused
  - Discussed Rahul Gandhi with neighbors - yes, no, don't know, refused
- In the past year, did you feel that the BJP was unified and had less infighting - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Any political engagement with BJP (did at least one of the following):
  - Receive any political messages from BJP by phone - yes, no, don't know, refused
  - Attend a BJP political meeting or election rally - yes, no, don't know, refused
  - Get contacted by a party worker from BJP - yes, no, don't know, refused
  - Attended a rally by a state leader - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Any political discourse about Narendra Modi (did at least one of the following)
  - Heard Narendra Modi discussed on television/phone - yes, no, don't know, refused
  - Discussed Narendra Modi with neighbors - yes, no, don't know, refused
- If the Lok Sabha election was held today, which party would you vote for?
- Which party did you vote for in the 2023 Vidhan Sabha election?

### **H.1.1 Validating Self-Reported Participation**

Because participation in the Bharat Jodo Yatra is self-reported, we examine whether the measure behaves in a manner consistent with actual opportunities for participation. We estimate a weighted linear probability model relating self-reported participation to the log distance between the respondent's location and the yatra route. As reported in Table H.1, respondents located farther from the yatra route were significantly less likely to report participating in the march ( $\beta = -0.013$ ,  $p < 0.01$ ). Although the estimated relationship is modest in magnitude, it is consistent with the expectation that opportunities for direct participation decline with geographic distance from the route. While this analysis cannot eliminate concerns about recall error or social desirability bias, it provides additional confidence that the self-reported participation measure captures meaningful variation in exposure to the Bharat Jodo Yatra.

Table H.1: Correlation between distance to yatra and reported participation in the yatra

| DV: Participate in BJY |                        |
|------------------------|------------------------|
| Log distance to BJY    | -0.0126***<br>(0.0041) |
| Observations           | 3475                   |
| Mean of DV             | 0.2                    |
| Weights                | Yes                    |

Notes: \*p<0.1; \*\*p<0.05; \*\*\*p<0.01. Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level.

## H.2 Survey Robustness

In the main text, we examine the relationship between participation in the yatra and a range of political outcomes using our survey data. Here we demonstrate robustness to conducting the analysis only on the Karnataka sample (Figure H.2), only on the Madhya Pradesh sample (Figure H.3), and with controls (Figure H.4).

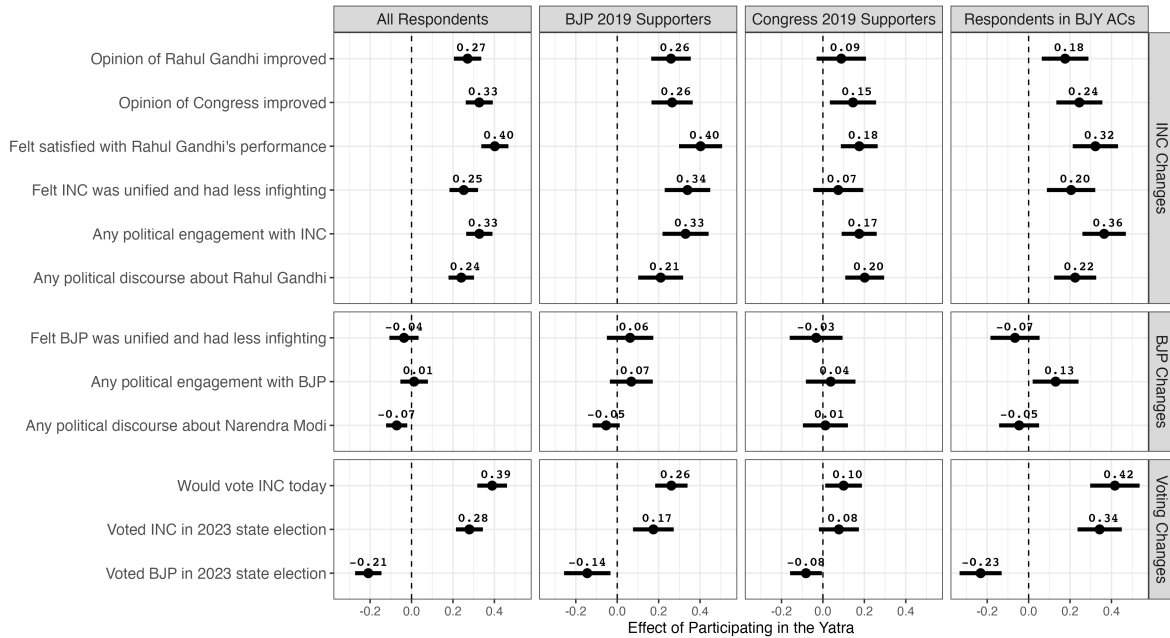


Figure H.2: Relationship between Participating in the Yatra and Political Outcomes (only Karnataka Sample)

## I Description of Interview Approach

To supplement our understanding of the Bharat Jodo Yatra and the mechanisms for increased Congress voter share we conducted 20 interviews with party leaders and workers, civil society organization leaders, and voters, primarily in Karnataka, seven months after the election (additional

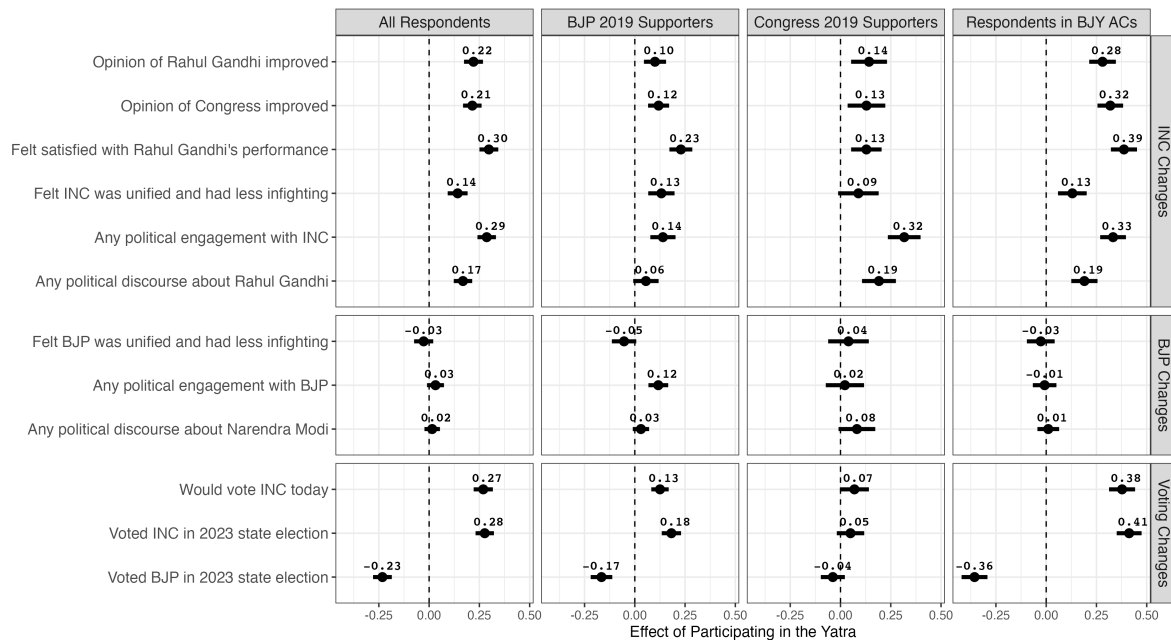


Figure H.3: Relationship between Participating in the Yatra and Political Outcomes (only Madhya Pradesh Sample)

interviews were also conducted over the phone and in Delhi with party functionaries involved in the overall BJY process). The party and organizational interviewees were sampled through a snowball sample from reaching out to initial party officials and from visiting the Congress party office in Bangalore. The voters were sampled in both Bangalore district and Mysore district through a snowball sample as well. These interviews are not structured to qualitatively test our argument but rather to supplement our understanding and ground-truth the mechanism for the BJY effects. We further recognize that party functionaries may describe the yatra impact in a particular way, so the interview evidence should be interpreted as perceptions of individuals rather than conclusive evidence of yatra changes. The interviews were approved by [Redacted University]'s Institutional Review Board.

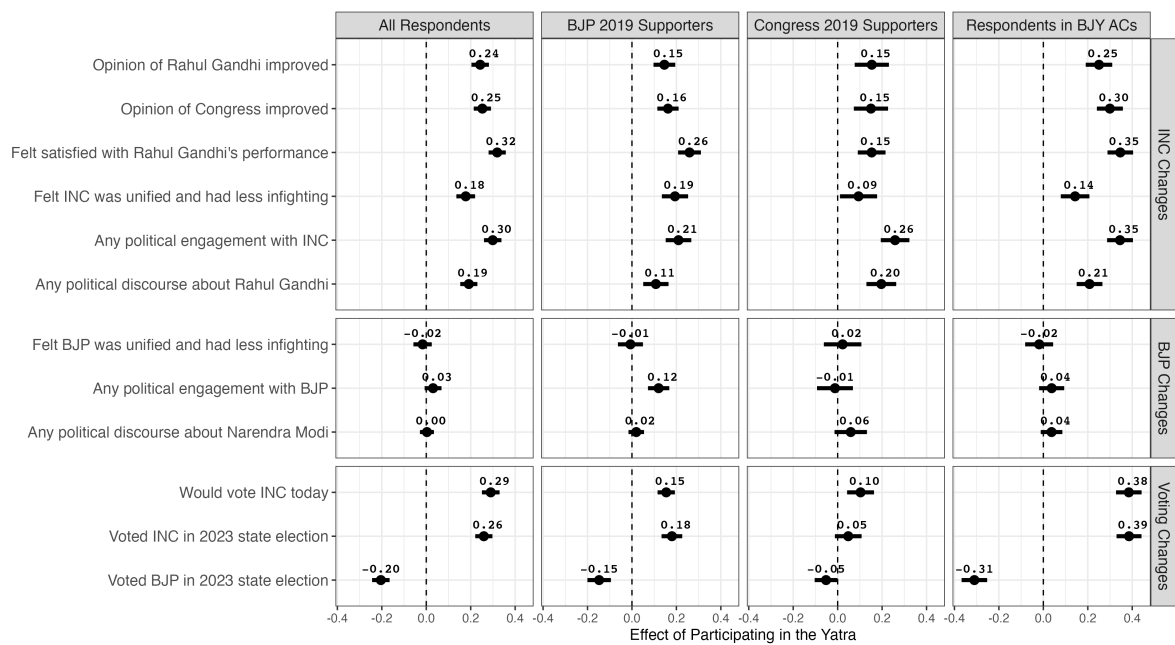


Figure H.4: Relationship between Participating in the Yatra and Political Outcomes (with Controls)

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